THE BISMARCK PLAN:
GERMAN UNIFICATION AND THE BALANCE OF POWER

JOHN A. SMOOT JR.

MASTERS OF ARTS IN DIPLOMACY AND MILITARY STUDIES

WINTER 2007

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Abstract

This paper is on the Bismarck Plan. The premise of this plan was to unify all the German principalities under Prussian rule. Once that was accomplished Bismarck adjusted his plan using treaties and alliances with other countries in Europe to keep war away from Germany for as long as possible or at least until Germany was ready militarily or diplomatically to defend herself.

In order to better understand where the idea of Bismarck's Plan came from, the origin of the ideas of nationalism and unification must first be discussed. No discussion on German unification would be complete without some background on Bismarck, not so much a biography of him, but more to give an idea of his thought process. The three wars of unification and their impact upon Europe along with each particular alliance and treaty that was made between Germany and the other European powers is central to Bismarck's plan. Some of these alliances and treaties directly involved Germany and some indirectly involved Germany. Each will be analyzed to see how they interrelate, and Bismarck's role. Bismarck's plan fell apart quickly after he left office.

From all of this it will be clear that Bismarck did indeed have a plan or a purpose if you will. The plan was not written down nor was it stated by Bismarck, if anything it was kept in his head. The purpose and the results of the plan are very clear in how fast Germany rose to prominence in Europe without really any threat of a major war. The Prussians were able to fight three minor wars without involving the entire continent. This is a testament to Bismarck and the goals that he set for Prussia and then Germany.

To Ellis

I am bored. The great things are done. The German Reich is made.

Prince Otto von Bismarck-Schonhausen

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ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

I want to personally thank Dr. Tom Basler and LtCol.(ret) Jeff Vandine for their logistical, technical and grammatical support in the writing of this paper. They were my second and third set of eyes without which I would never have been able to complete this paper. Tom your logistical expertise in connection with the library system was crucial in me being able to get the reference materials needed in the remote island of Key West. Jeff, your guidance was just as crucial as it was you who helped me keep my thoughts going in the right direction. I'd like to thank my mother whose constant questions on the status of this paper helped me to push through in the toughest of times. I'd also like to thank the History department at Hawaii Pacific University for their patience and understanding with the length of time it took to complete this paper. Lastly, I'd like to thank my family who had to deal with books strewn all over the place, tempers when the printer didn't work, weekends of not going anywhere or with Dad locking himself in the bedroom/office. Marie, Ashley and Trey this paper would not have been possible at all if you all had not been there. Thank you.

Introduction

The Bismarck Plan: German Unification and the Balance of Power

The Great War, or World War I as it would be later known, forever changed the makeup of Europe. Of the major European powers, before that time, France gained the prestige lost during the Napoleonic Wars and the Franco-Prussian War but at a very devastating cost to the population and countryside. The empires of Germany, Austria-Hungary and Turkey collapsed. So, did Russia, triggering the Russian Revolution and providing the bedrock for the Soviet Union. Additionally, the war thrust the United States and Japan onto the world stage.[1]

There are multiple causes of World War I, including secret treaties and alliances, failed foreign policies, nationalism and distrust by all countries involved. Of particular interest, however, is the massive shift in the European balance of power caused by the unification of Germany and Italy in the latter part of the 19th century. A detailed discussion of the origin of this idea, who orchestrated the action and what resulted follows.

The unification of Germany was principally the plan of one man, Prince Otto Eduard Leopold von Bismarck-Schonhausen. Bismarck's plan was not formally committed to paper. Nonetheless, he knew what needed to be done for the unification, where he wanted Germany positioned, and how to manipulate events as to reach that goal. What he needed, for the success of such a plan, were events to occur that could give him reason to take action. To facilitate such a plan, Bismarck roughly needed four actions: (1) the exclusion of Austria from the German Confederation; (2) the encouragement of

[1] Hew Strachan. *The First World War.* (New York: Penguin Group, Inc., 2004). 1.

German principalities to join Prussia to form the German Empire; (3) the building of the financial infrastructure and military strength of the new Empire; and finally (4) the creation of alliances with other major European powers that would be so complex as to keep the focus off of war allowing German growth.

Unification in Germany was not unique to Bismarck's time. Review of the origins of this concept culminating in actual unification under Bismarck's leadership is essential to understanding early and modern Germany. Since Bismarck is crucial to this idea, understanding his life and his nearly 30 years of public work is also essential. The complex, often convoluted, series of diplomatic maneuverings, alliances and wars to achieve the unification is daunting. Then again, the political mastermind behind the action was as complex. This period of time defined both the man and his resulting new nation.

Historiography

Of the readings that I have done on Bismarck, I have only found one resource that mentions anything about a specific plan that he may have had for Germany. However, it is mentioned and not really looked into. Most of the historians focus on Bismarck himself. I have found countless sources and writings on Bismarck, the man and the statesman. I have also read books that focus on how Bismarck is able to maneuver other countries into what he wants them to do. There are also extensive works on the wars of unification. The one thing that I am amazed at is that there are a few works on the alliances and treaties of that time. There are some analytical works on them, but

not a lot of really in depth analysis on each alliance, treaty, convention, and congress. Most have been taken a historical approach, few have done some analysis and pieced them all together, but none have done anything really in depth on how each one of these alliances were interrelated. In part one we will look at the period beginning with the early Roman Empire and ending at about the time Bismarck comes to power in 1862. It is in this timeframe that the seeds of German unity are planted and begin to develop. German unity actually began with the French during the revolution. Although not much is written about German/Prussian domestic policies in this period there is an abundance of scholarly writings about the French Revolution, its impact on Europe and the foreign policy of the different French governments during the revolution. T. C. W. Blanning's *The French Revolution in Europe* gives a comprehensive view of just what the French wanted to do with the German states during the revolutionary wars. Blanning's main focus is the area of the Rhineland. He looks into French foreign policy, nationalism and delves into why the Rhenish people rejected what the French were doing to such an extent that it would become necessary for the French to annex this region. *European Diplomatic History 1789-1815: France Against Europe* by Steven Ross is an excellent book on French diplomacy and foreign policy in Europe. In it, Ross discusses the Directory's plans to create a "Third Germany" of loyal principalities united together in support of France and to provide a buffer against Austria and Prussia. Ross also points out that when Napoleon came into power he kept up and also furthered the Directory's policy of the "Third Germany". Paul Schroeder's *The Transformation of European Politics, 1763-1848* reveals its unifying theme; the collapse of the eighteenth-century international system in a generation of great systemic wars from 1787 to 1812,

the painful construction of a new international system from 1813 to 1815, and the successful operation of that system, giving Europe its most peaceful, progressive era of international politics ever. In it he shows how France and then the rest of Europe (Austria, England and Russia) basically put Prussia in a position of trying to unify the German peoples to be able to survive in the new Europe. In *Germany from Napoleon to Bismarck, 1800-1866* by Thomas Nipperdey, we visit a subject of passionate debates, the beginnings of German nationalism. Nipperdey gives a thorough going exploration, from the dissolution of the Holy Roman Empire to Bismarck's division of the German-speaking world into three parts: an enlarged Prussian state north of the Main, an isolated Austria-Hungary in the south, and a group of Catholic states in between. Nipperdey examines the fate of the German society from the revolutions of 1848-49 to the rise of Bismarck. Showing how future generations were ingrained with the idea of unified German peoples.

Part two looks at the man who unified Germany with a Prussian king, defeated France and Austria, caused the fall of the Second Empire, brought about the alliance of the German Empire and the Habsburg Monarchy, and the dismemberment of Denmark. Prince Otto Eduard Leopold von Bismarck-Schonhausen, known as the "Iron Chancellor", was able to unify all the German principalities through wars with Austria, Denmark, and France without involving the rest of Europe. In this part we will look at Bismarck, the man. Not just his accomplishments, but what actually drove him to do what he did. Erich Eyck gives us an insight to how Bismarck worked his political and diplomatic maneuverings to get what he wanted in *Bismarck, the Man and the Statesman*. To Eyck, the one thing that Bismarck does that stands out the most was

the transformation of the national consciousness of the German people. In *Bismarck*, Edward Crankshaw goes in to depth on Bismarck giving us quite a bit of information on his early years and the things in life that made him who he was. No work about Bismarck and his accomplishments would be complete without using Bismarck's own words and thoughts. Dictated by Bismarck himself and translated from German to English by A.J. Butler, *Bismarck, the Man and the Statesman* gives us the most comprehensive look into Otto von Bismarck that anyone could hope to have. His arrogance, dislike of certain people and standards that he set people to are all revealed in his own words. You also get an insight into just how events and people shaped him into the headstrong chancellor who unified Germany.

The German wars of unification are the main focus of the third part. In it we will be looking at how Bismarck maneuvered Denmark, Austria, and France into three separate wars that he used to pull all the German principalities together with the Prussian king at its head. In *Franz Joseph and Bismarck; the Diplomacy of Austria before the War of 1866*, Chester Wells Clark looks at the diplomacy of Bismarck and the foreign policy of Austria that turned Austria from an ally to an enemy in two short years. Clark focuses on how Austria's foreign policy of 1866 was conditioned by a weakening internal structure in the Hapsburg Empire prior to the struggle of 1866. William Carr's *The Origins of the Wars of German Unification*, gives us an overall picture of what exactly was going on in Europe from 1866 to 1871. Carr examines the international, strategic, economic, ideological, and political context of the three conflicts. With a separate chapter for each conflict, Carr is able to give a detailed examination of what was going on in each country involved in the arenas of foreign policy, diplomacy, and the military.

Describing the interaction between the "stream of time"--or social, political, intellectual, and institutional forces--and the character of one of history's greatest political talents, Otto Pflanze probes Bismarck's role in the unification of Germany and assesses his influence on the subsequent course of German history in volume one of his *Bismarck and the Development of Germany; the Period of Unification, 1815-1871*. Pflanze offers fresh insights into the functioning of both the internal and international political systems of the Bismarck era. At the same time Bismarck, the man, has not been neglected. The author produces a vivid picture of this narcissistic personality, demonstrating the connections among health, neurosis, and political judgment. For the first time we can see the entire person and how his strengths and weaknesses became the key to modern German history.

In the fourth part the focus will be on the intertwining alliances, conferences, treaties, and agreements that connected all the European countries. William Langer's *European Alliances and Alignments*, *1870-1890*, describes the building of the intricate Bismarckian system of security down to the Kaiser's dismissal of its architect in 1890. Comprehensive and very in depth, the author is able to weave you through each alliance, treaty, conference, and agreement to show how alliances shifted frequently in the period of 1870 to 1890. With the focus on Bismarck, Langer gives us a view of a man who will do anything to protect Germany from all the other foreign powers. *The Congress of Berlin and After*, by William N. Medlicott gives us a much clearer view of all the political intrigue and diplomatic maneuverings of the countries involved. Medlicott shows how Bismarck was able to use the situations at hand to manipulate people into doing what he wanted. Although not getting what he wanted all the time, Bismarck was

able to come out of the Congress in a much better position for himself and for Germany than he was in before the congress. This book also follows through on how each country felt or how foreign policies shifted after the congress. The author is able to show us just how fragile Europe was when it came to the "Eastern Question", a problem that would blossom into a devastating war in 1914. One of the most extensive books on Europe in the nineteenth century is A.J.P. Taylor's *The Struggle for the Mastery of Europe, 1848-1918.* Although used throughout this paper, its main usage is to help fill in gaps that Langer missed in his book *European Alliances and Alignments*, *1870-1890.*

In 1890 Wilhelm II dismissed Bismarck from an office that he had held for more than thirty years. Many people believed that after he was dismissed that the system he had set up would not survive without him. John Reohl in *Germany without Bismarck* shows how the system did not fail but stayed together until 1918. However, Reohl points out that the first seven years after Bismarck's departure, his system went through a severe crisis. Basically it was a crisis in leadership. When Bismarck was the chancellor, he ruled almost every aspect of the government. When he left, others began to divvy up certain offices and responsibilities for themselves. It took until 1897 for Wilhelm II to finally get control of the government and emerge as the decisive figure in government. Charlotte Sempell's article *The Constitutional and Political Problems of the Second Chancellor, Leo von Caprivi* gives us a look into the brief four year reign of Germany's second chancellor. Sempell shows us how Caprivi's military background seemed to prevail in the way he handled German foreign relations. He was not a diplomat nor did he have any background in diplomacy. This proved to be a great failing for Caprivi. However, in the area of domestic affairs, Caprivi brought about long overdue reforms

that helped strengthen Prussia and make her the strongest state in the Empire. To show how all the European countries were spiraling towards war in the years before 1914 excerpts are pulled from Joll's *The Origins of the First World War* and Kissinger's *Diplomacy*. The biggest factor that both authors point out is the distrust and failed diplomacy that caused the slide into war. The other factor was the rising up of the "Eastern Question" for the final time.

The original idea for The Bismarck Plan came from a paper I did for another class that dealt with the intertwining alliances of the period during and after German unification. While doing the paper I noticed a pattern in the way the alliances were set up and how they came to be. I began looking into the wars of unification and how they began and I notice what looked to be a very haphazard pattern. After doing some reading on Bismarck and learning about the man more, I came to the conclusion that he knew what he was doing. He had a goal (a unified Germany with Prussian leadership) so he began to formulate a plan on how to achieve this. His plan was not set in stone; in fact it was very flexible allowing him to act on any circumstance that would allow him to get closer to his goal. It was a very intricate plan and it seems very few (if any) people could understand it. Once Germany was unified, he then adjusted his plan so that he could keep the other European powers from destroying her until she was strong enough to fend for herself. This paper will be looking into the areas of Foreign Policy and Diplomacy exclusively. There will be some exploration into the military aspect but it will only be to show how Bismarck used the military to force his foreign policy and diplomacy or as a tool to achieve his goal through force as he did in the wars of unification. The biggest weakness that I have encountered during the research phase

of this paper is my inability to read German or French. I think if I could read either of these languages I would have more primary sources than the few that I do have. Another weakness that I have had to work around is the lack of research materials in the area where I live. To work around this I have been fortunate enough to have a stepfather who is the dean of the Medical Library of South Carolina. He has used his connections to enable me to withdraw books from the College of Charleston, Citadel, and Thomas Cooper Library of the University of South Carolina. Using these sources I have been able to get enough research material to support my thesis.

A government must not waiver once it has chosen its course. It must not look left or right but go forward.

Prince Otto von Bismarck-Schonhausen

Chapter I

The Rise of European Nationalism and the Idea of German Unification

In 1871, at Versailles, the seat of the old French monarchy, the German Empire was first officially proclaimed. In a ceremony full of symbolic implication, just 170 years after the coronation of the first King in Prussia at Königsberg,[2] this Second German Empire was founded and proclaimed on the foreign soil of conquered France.[3] Although the formal treaty would not be signed for many months afterward, William I 1871 crowning signaled the end of the Franco-Prussian war, the final act in the unification of the German principalities under Prussian rule. This was the culmination of Prince Otto von Bismarck's vision to leverage Prussia's successes to unite all the German states.

Leading up to this event, Bismarck, Chancellor of the Prussian state, was acutely aware that he had to take care not to upset the balance of power in Europe causing the powerful nations of Austria, England, France, and Russia to unite against his cause. To this end he involved Prussia in three short wars that would remove Austria from Germany, consolidate all German principalities with a controlling Prussian monarchy, and establish the now forming New Germany as a European Power. Cooperating militarily Prussia and Austria waged war against Denmark in 1864. The Prussians gained advantages upon the defeat of Denmark in both the gain of territory (Schleswig) and leverage against Austria, who served as administrator of the Holstein territory. The squabble over Holstein connected with the reform of the German Bund in the interests

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[2] A territory outside the old Holy Roman Empire.

[3] Imanuel Geiss. *German Foreign Policy, 1871-1914*. (London: Routledge, 1976). 5.

of Prussia, furnished the immediate cause of the Austro-Prussian War of 1866 against Austria and nearly all of the remaining German principalities (in particular Saxony, Hanover, Hesse, Baden, Württemberg, and Bavaria).[4]

The Battle of Sadowa, in July of 1867, not only decided Prussia's ascendancy in Germany but also finally broke the backbone of the domestic German "liberalism" movement. The result was that most liberals made their peace with Bismarck and supported him through the founding of the National Liberal Party the following year. By incorporating the Poles in the eastern provinces of Prussia who had not formed part of the old Empire into the North German Federation, and through the protest of their spokesmen in Parliament, it was decided that the new German Empire would also be burdened with the liability of the partition of Poland. Austria was thrown out of Germany and, in reaction to her defeat, was reorganized in 1867 under pressure of the Magyars by means of a constitutional compromise to form the Dual Monarchy, Austria-Hungary.[5]

Prussian's annexation of Hanover, Northern Hesse, and Frankfurt enabled them to form the North German Confederation. This left the remaining Southern German states, whose only unifying motive was the common desire to preserve their own autonomy, still outside a "New German Empire". Through Bismarck's clever manipulation of the liberal and constitutional movement and his superior diplomacy, these activities had also maneuvered France into isolation, as the last apparent "enemy" to oppose German unification. This position also precipitated war.

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[4] Ibid., 5-6.

[5] Ibid.

The resulting Franco-Prussian War, was joined by all the German states, including those of the southern German areas, was won by the efficient organization and strategic leadership of the united German armies coupled with a numerical superiority in manpower. While a Russian intervention managed to neutralize Austria-Hungary, Prussian leadership forced the German unified effort through a continued conflict with France after the defeat of Napoleon III at Sedan with the aim of annexing Alsace-Lorraine.[6]

Although, Bismarck is credited with accomplishing this goal, the concept of the unification of the German states was an idea that had been voiced for centuries. A better understanding of the issues, values and difficulties of the German Unification concept would come through review of the earlier attempts at unification. In the following pages we will look at the early attempts to unify Germany from Arminius[7] to Charlemagne and the Holy Roman Empire. We will then look at the French Revolution and how it affected both nationalism and unification in the German states. From there we will turn to the Napoleonic era and Napoleon's plans for German consolidation under French tutelage. After that we will examine what happened after the defeat of Napoleon at the Congress of Vienna where Prussia gained some prestige and ideas of German unification really began to develop with nationalistic fervor. Finally we will look at the revolutions and uprisings of 1848 and beyond that gave impetus to Prussian thoughts of a unified Germany.

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[6] Ibid.

[7] Also known as Hermann

The first instances of Germanic tribal-level unification came about in opposition of neighboring Rome in the 2nd Century B.C. Tribes such as the Suevi, Cherusci and other Germanic tribes occupied much of Germany territory. The Cimbri and Teutons invaded Gaul and were defeated in present-day Provence, France.[8] When the Romans attempted to conquer the area east of the Rhine River early in the 1st century, they were defeated by a collection of allied tribes led by the Cherusci chief Arminius at the Teutoburg Forest in A.D. 9.[9] It was also during this time that German mercenaries were beginning to be used by the Roman armies.

Throughout the 3rd century, more tribal migrations caused a crisis within the empire, as Goths, Alemanni, and Franks penetrated the Roman frontiers. The movement stopped temporarily in the late 3rd century during the reigns of the emperors Diocletian and Constantine the Great,[10] though it resumed under pressure from the Huns, who came out of Central Asia in the 4th century.[11] By the 5th century the Germans occupied the whole of the Western Roman Empire.

Clovis I, King of the Franks, considered the founder of the Merovingian monarchy, was originally little more than a tribal chieftain when he became sole leader of the Salian Franks. In 486 he defeated the Roman legions under Syagrius at Soissons, virtually ending Roman domination over Gaul and extending Frankish rule to most of the

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[8] William G. Sinnigen, and Arthur E.R. Boak. *A History of Rome to A.D. 565.* 6th ed. (New York: Macmillan Publishing Co., Inc., 1977). 179.

[9] Adrian Keith Goldsworthy,. *The Roman Army at War: 100 B.C. – A.D. 200.* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1996). 43.

10 Peter S. Wells. *The Battle That Stopped Rome: Emperor Augustus, Arminius, and the Slaughter of the Legions in the Teutoburg Forest*. (New York: W. W. Norton and Company, 2003). 15-18.

[11] Jack Holland and John Monroe. *The Order of Rome: Imperium Romanum; Charlemagne and the Holy Roman Empire*. (Boston: Boston Publishing Company, Inc., 1986). 86.

area North of the Loire.[12] He then subdued the Thuringians. He is said to have invoked the Christian God while locked in battle with the Alemanni in the late 490s and converted to Christianity, having been persuaded by his wife Clotilda and the bishop St. Remigius of Reims who baptized him. With the defeat of the Alemanni and his conversion, Clovis I had now aligned himself with the powerful religious establishment in Rome[13] to become the champion of Christianity against the Arian heretics, the Visigoths. He attacked and defeated the Visigoths under Alaric II at Vouillé in 507, bringing most of Gaul under his rule. Clovis, whose base of operations was Paris, had united all Franks under his rule while gaining the support of the Gallic clergy, and extended his conquests into Germany. He became master of most of Gaul and Southwest Germany by the time he died in 511. Thus, he laid the foundation of the French monarchy and foreshadowed the conquests of Charlemagne.[14]

Charlemagne was crowned "Roman Emperor" in 800 A.D. beginning the rule of the Carolingian dynasty. His crowning by the Pope had two major outcomes. First, it gave the Pope the highest temporal power of all – that of kingmaker. Second, it made people believe that the glory of the old Roman Empire was being rekindled.[15] It was Charlemagne's purpose and intent to step further than Clovis, to unite Europe into one large empire under the power of a single Christian ruler.[16] However, before this vision

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[12] Sinnigen, 514.

[13] Ibid., 470.

[14] Ibid.

[15] Holland, 101.

[16] Ibid, 140.

of a unified Europe would become a reality, the formation of the German Reich took place. The creation of the Reich was a long developmental process that began in 843 when the grandsons of Charlemagne divided the Frankish Empire into three parts; Middle Francia (Rhine corridor and Italy), Western Francia (France), and Eastern Francia (Germany).[17] Characteristic of the ensuing development of East Francia, it was Louis II "the German" who first claimed power over the territory east of the rivers Rhine and Aare. In 885, the East and the West reunited under the patronage of Charles III "the Fat"; but in 911, after the death of Louis IV "the Child", the era of the Frankish Empire came to an end.[18]

From this time, the largely German East Francian Empire started to evolve independently of the West. The nobles of the German part of the Empire, realizing the need for a central national power, gave the German throne to a Franconian duke, Conrad I. He spent most of his seven-year reign in conflict with a Saxon duke, Henry, whom he would eventually name his successor.[19] With the coronation of Henry I "the Fowler", Duke of Saxony, as king of East Francia in 919, the Carolingian dynasty ceased to exist and the Ottonian Saxon dynasty began. The Saxons with which Charlemagne fought were now furnishing the king who would begin restoring the Roman Empire.[20] Henry's son, Otto I, who became emperor in 962, was responsible for the resurgence. Otto, known as Otto the Great, has been called the Charlemagne of

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[17] Ibid., 104.

[18] Thomas Prey, "German Unification and European Intergration" (Senior Thesis, The American University in Paris, 1995).

[19] Holland, 106.

[20] Ibid.

Germany. Though, he lacked Charlemagne's intellectual and cultural ambition, he was a strong willed and clever ruler. By a series of shrewd political maneuvers, he succeeded in winning the loyalty of the German feudal barons and fused their separate fiefdoms into a moderately coherent state. Otto now ruled all of Germany.[21] Thus, at the beginning of the 11th century, the awareness of the concept of being "German" grew and by the end of the same century, it had become custom to call East Francia the "German Empire" and its people "Germans".[22] What had emerged was the "altes deutsches Reich",[23] the informal term for a German Empire that was to last nearly nine hundred years from 911 to 1806.[24]

On the larger scale, it was not until the 12th century that Charlemagne's original European dream first became reality. Frederick Barbarossa temporarily restored the Roman Empire, including Germany, adding to it the territory of Italy. During his reign (1152-1190) he saw Germany and Italy as a sacred entity established on earth directly by God. He began referring to the empire not merely as the Roman Empire but as the "Holy" Roman Empire. Part of this was to assert his status as religious equal to the Pope.[25] However, with the death of his grandson Frederick II in 1250 A.D., who's policy was of making Italy the center of his power, and who was interested in Germany only because it guaranteed to him his title to Upper and Central Italy, the grandeur of the

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[21] Ibid.

[22] It must be noted that Nationalism (as implied by modern use of the term "German") did not exist. To be "German" was more of a cultural concept. It will not be until later in the 18th century that Nationalism becomes a driving force in Central Europe.

[23] Roughly translated it means Old German Realm.

[24] Prey.

[25] Holland, 122.

Empire once again disappeared. Thus, while strong kings controlling significantly centralized nations ruled Spain, France, and England, Germany increasingly became subject to the influence of feudal lords.

In the sixteenth century, during the Empire's struggle with the Pope, it adopted the addition 'of the German Nation' to its official name. Originally a cover for the claims of German tribes or their leaders to a kind of dominance over Christian Europe, the Empire degenerated. From the second half of the thirteenth century, Germany fell into a loose confederation of hundreds of states ranging in size from the minute (Saxe-Weimar, Swabia) to the two great states (Austria and Prussia).[26] The Thirty Years War, one of the great conflicts of early modern European history, consisting of a series of declared and undeclared wars, which raged through the years 1618-1648 throughout central Europe, eventually brought an end to both the German and the European vision of unity. The war as a whole may be considered a struggle of German Protestant princes and foreign powers (France, Sweden, Denmark, England, the United Provinces) against the unity and power of the Holy Roman Empire as represented by the Hapsburgs, allied with the Catholic princes, and against the Hapsburgs themselves. When it concluded, with the Treaty of Westphalia (at Munster on 24 October 1648), it left fundamental changes in the makeup of Europe.[27] In addition to establishing Switzerland and the

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[26] Geiss, 3.

[27] Other events that affected the Holy Roman Empire at the same time were the encroaching Turks to the east. This tended to make Austria wary of what was happening on both fronts, but more importantly to be ready to protect herself against the Turkish invaders.

Dutch Republic[28] as independent states, the treaty gravely weakened the Holy Roman Empire and the Austrian ruling family, the Habsburgs, by giving the German princes rights to conclude alliances.[29] More significantly, the sovereignty and independence of each of the 350-odd states of the Holy Roman Empire was now at last formally recognized, reducing the emperor's power in German affairs.[30] Two other effects of the treaty were the assurance of the emergence of France as the chief power on the continent, and the terribly harmful retardation of the political unification of Germany. The Reich continued to exist in name, but it was nothing more than a loose confederation of the various German princes who happened to support the Hapsburg rule of Austria. Although the Hapsburgs exercised real authority only in Austria, they continued to go through the solemn medieval charade of crowning emperor after emperor.[31]

One German Prince who took advantage of being able to conclude alliances and establish sovereignty was Frederick William, elector of Brandenburg. He established the independence of the duchy of Prussia from Poland at the Peace of Oliva in 1660. Also known as "The Great Elector", he was instrumental in instituting reforms that helped to create the Prussian army. When Frederick William assumed the throne in 1640, the victorious factions of the Thirty Years War had reduced his authority over his

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[28] From the formation of the Union of Utrecht in 1579, these provinces were able to remain a separate republic but it was not until the Treaty of Westphalia, at the conclusion of the Thirty Years War in 1648, that the independence of the Republic of the United Provinces of the Netherlands was finally recognized.

[29] Robert A. Kann. *A History of the Habsburg Empire: 1526-1918*. (Berkley: University of California Press, 1974). 52.

[30] Holland, 166.

[31] Ibid.

realm. The Elector knew that the key to safety lay in military force. He also knew that to build up a military force he needed the support of the Estates of Brandenburg, Cleves, Mark and East Prussia.[32] The key to his success in this area was an arrangement he made with his Brandenburg Estates that basically gave them certain rights and privileges over their lands in exchange for military service and complete loyalty to the Elector. These Junkers as they were called would become the nucleus of the fledgling army but would also provide the officer corps of later generations. During his reign the army of Brandenburg-Prussia not only demonstrated that it was capable of defending the territories of its own but by its victories at Warsaw and Fehrbellin, won the consideration and respect of the Great Powers, a fact adequately demonstrated by the eagerness with which Brandenburg-Prussia's aid was solicited in the Elector's last years.[33] In 1701, Frederick I, Frederick William's son, became the first king of the Prussia. He was able to do this by exchanging military aid with royal recognition from the Holy Roman Emperor, Leopold I. Although, generally considered to be a weak ruler because of his love for ceremonial display, Frederick nevertheless respected the realities of power. He recognized the army as the bulwark of his authority; and gradually increased its strength until it stood at 40,000 men.[34] Frederick's son, Frederick William the First increased the size and efficiency of the army and organized the state around the military establishment.[35] At the same time he freed Prussia from

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[32] Gordon A. Craig. *The Politics of the Prussian Army: 1640-1945.* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1964). 3-4.

[33] Craig, *The Politics of the Prussian Army,* 5-7.

[34] Ibid., 7.

[35] Ernest R. May. *Strange Victory: Hitler's Conquest of France*. (New York: Hill and Wang, 2000). 24-25.

the dependence upon foreign subsidies, which had, in previous reigns, involved the Hohenzollerns[36] in wars, which did not always advance their own interests.[37] He left enormous financial reserves and the best army in Europe to his son, Frederick II, "the Great" who through his military genius Prussia became a major power in Europe. In 1740 he invaded the Austrian province of Silesia and precipitated the War of the Austrian Succession. By winning Silesia and proving his ability to retain it, he destroyed the old German constitution and raised Prussia to a position of virtual equality with Austria. During the Seven Years War the reconciliation between the king and his nobles was finally completed, while the officer corps became the embodiment of the spirit of devotion to the Crown and the state. Moreover, the common foot-soldier gained a consciousness of his own ability which, handed on to his successors, was to make Prussian troops the finest soldiers in Europe. Prussia was now known as 'an army with a state rather than a state with an army'; such was the level of militarisation throughout its society.[38] The achievements of the army, crowned with success the process begun by the Great Elector and Frederick William I, effected a fundamental change in the European balance of power, and established beyond question Prussia's elevation to Great Power status.[39]

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[36] Prussia's ruling family.

[37] Ibid., 8.

[38] Tim Chapman. *The Congress of Vienna: Origin, Process and Results*. (London: Routledge, 1998). 24.

[39] Craig, *The Politics of the Prussian Army,* 13-14.

The late 17th and early 18th centuries brought new ideas to all Europeans with the dawn of the Age of Enlightenment.[40] The Age of Enlightenment was a time when man started to question everything, including the authority of God and king. A product of the Renaissance and the Scientific Revolution, the Age of Enlightenment saw man thinking in ways and ideas that that were new and alien. Ideas expounded by Voltaire and Rousseau held the literate captive. These ideas were appealing to the Bourgeoisie because they promised free commerce and liberal personal freedom. Thinkers also challenged the dogmas of absolutism. Reason, they believed, was a higher force than the monarch's claim to divine right. Thus, the brotherhood of men, equal rights, and responsibilities should replace privilege, and individuals should develop through opportunity and education and not birth. They became critical of absolutism, the class system, privilege, and the lack of liberal rights. The populace began to question their place in the universe and society. The signing of the Treaty of Versailles in 1783 between the American colonies and Britain, establishing a government theoretically run "by the people," espoused the ideals of the Age of Enlightenment. It was these ideals that played a major role in the French Revolution.

In 1789 France erupted in revolution, which would eventually encompass all of Europe. It was the beginning of the end of the old order. The French Revolution also marked the turning point in the growth of modern nationalism. It contributed two concepts to political philosophy that had been used in the American Revolution. The first concept was that the secular state recognized no higher authority than itself, and thus no longer sought legitimization from the Church. The second concept, the notion

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[40] Also known as the Age of Reason.

of equality of citizens was a mixed blessing. While the state guaranteed to the individual the enjoyment of certain rights the quid pro quo was the obligation to serve the community and, if need be, give his life in its defense.[41] The doctrines of the French Revolution challenged every state in Europe whose existence rested less on power than on the old traditional legal order, most of whom (the Low Countries, Germany, Switzerland, and Italy) were France's neighbors. The changes in France's government from an absolute monarchy to a government, at least nominally, representative of the people, as well as the wholesale slaughter of the traditional power elite during the reign of terror, caused European monarchs to fear revolution. This French challenge was rendered doubly dangerous by what citizens in Austria, Prussia, and Russia had already done and were doing at present to undermine the legal order. The French Revolution, was often perceived as a threat to the international system, mainly because its example and doctrines incited neighboring peoples to revolution, and thereby spurred neighboring governments to counterrevolution.

Nonetheless, by and large, this never happened. The states to the north and east of France, especially in the German Rhineland, were too small, divided, and diverse in character for any general revolutionary movement to take hold. Moreover, the lines of authority and fealty within them were too loose and intertwined. Ironically, the trouble was rather that the same loose, traditional character of these regimes which kept them from being likely objects of revolution also made them incapable of defending themselves against French revolutionary attack and subversion. They could not unite for defense without threatening their own individual existence. They could not call on

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[41] William Carr. *The Origins of the Wars of German Unification*. (New York: Pearson Education Inc., 1991). 2.

their peoples for great sacrifices without undermining their allegiance. And finally, they dared not rely on other great powers for protection because these powers were in some respects more dangerous to them than France.[42] Thus, the Revolution did not really pit France against the great monarchies of Europe - at least not at first. Instead, Revolutionary France joined in a political and intellectual attack that was already being waged by other great powers against what remained of the legal international order in Europe and the smaller intermediary bodies dependent upon it. Only later, when threatened, did France turn its revolutionary forces mainly against great powers.[43]

When France presented the notion of abolishing absolutism, and ultimately the monarchy, the European monarchs became fearful that this concept would spread to their countries. Both Austrian Emperor Leopold II (brother to Marie Antoinette) and King Frederick William II issued the Declaration of Pillnitz. Signed 27 August 1791, this document announced that the predicament of the French King was an object of common concern to all of the European courts. Leopold and Frederick William expressed the hope that the other powers in conjunction with Austria and Prussia would seek the most effective means to restore the liberty of the French sovereign.[44] In France, Jacques Pierre Brissot led the pro-war Jacobins.[45] Brissot and his followers felt that war would enable the government to take drastic measures against the domestic

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[42] Paul W Schroeder. *The Transformation of European Politics, 1763-1848*. (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1994). 73-74.

[43] Ibid.

[44] Steven T.Ross. *European Diplomatic History, 1789-1815; France Against Europe*. (Malabar: Robert E. Krieger Publishing Company, Inc.,1981). 37.

enemies of the Revolution. It would also force Louis XVI to reveal his true hostile attitude towards the new regime, thus enabling the Assembly to depose him and establish a republic. Brissot's Girondists[46] increasingly put pressure on the Legislative Assembly for France to declare war on Austria and Prussia. The Girondists did not hold a majority in the Assembly, allowing the Legislative Assembly to present Austria and Prussia with a set of demands before going to war. However, when these demands were refused, the movement gained even more support in their calls for war.

War was seen by this time as a way to spread the successful French revolutionary cause of "liberty, equality, and fraternity" to all parts of Europe. It was also seen as a chance to unite all of the French under one banner to defend France. However, by 1792, foreign wars complicated and influenced the pattern of internal strife and upheaval within France. In order to protect their revolution, and their nation, the French devised a new radical scheme of military organization that would enable them to marshal the human and material resources of the entire country. This new tactical style, known as the levee en masse, would ultimately turn the new citizen army into the most formidable fighting force in Europe. The French would successfully defend their homeland and then carry their banners into the heart of the Continent.[47]

The physical impact of the French Revolution on Germany was enormous. Tension soon developed between the new revolutionary government and the Holy Roman

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[45] Formed in 1789 by the Breton deputies to the States-General, it was reconstituted as the Society of Friends of the Constitution after the revolutionary National Assembly moved (Oct. 1789) to Paris. The club derived its popular name from the monastery of the Jacobins (Parisian name of Dominicans).

[46] The term Girondists is a post revolutionary term used to describe Brissot and his followers. It came about because most of Brissot's important followers came from the department of the Gironde. During the 1790's they were known as Brissotin. See Ross, *European Diplomatic History* (Malabar, 1981).

[47] Ross, 21-22.

Empire. The revolutionaries were suspicious of the counter-revolutionary activities of émigré noblemen in the Rhineland, while West German princes were embittered by the abolition of feudalism in their Alsace estates. With the Girondists in power in France in 1792 and the new Emperor Francis II, eager to do battle with the enemies of monarchy, war was inevitable. War was declared, on Austria and Prussia, in April of that year, though not until 1793 did the Holy Roman Empire declare war on France in return.[48] The clash of arms soon revealed the pitiful inadequacy of imperial defenses and the moral bankruptcy of the Empire. By 1794 France was in control of the Rhineland and remained so for the next twenty years. The German princes soon abandoned their halfhearted resistance and came to terms with the conquerors.[49]

It was not the intention of France, however, to spread her revolutionary fervor throughout Europe as much as it was to protect her own Revolutionary government from outside intervention. With the defeat of the German and other European powers, the French Directory began to bind the German principalities to France by a program of compensations and secularizations,[50] and to establish French satellites in Germany.[51] These principalities would supply much needed men, money, food, and other supplies to help the French in their war. And further, they would provide a buffer zone between

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[48] Even though Francis II was both Emperor of the Holy Roman Empire and Austria, the Treaty of Westphalia had significantly weakened his power in the Holy Roman Empire to the extent that the other principalities actually had a say if they were going to war or not.

[49] Carr, 8.

[50] Defined as drawing away from religious orientation. These principalities had been held together for many centuries by the power of religion. The secularizations show that since the Thirty Years War the Holy Roman Empire had been dying a slow death.

[51] Schroeder, 169.

the French and the other major European powers (with the exception of England to the East). General Louis Lazare Hoche proposed that the Rhineland be made into the Cisrhenan Republic that would owe its allegiance to France.[52] The French Directory had other ideas and began the process of annexing the German province. On 17 October 1797 the Peace of Campo Formio was concluded, between France and Austria, bringing an end to the war, with General Napoleon Bonaparte, representing the French Republic and Count Ludwig von Cobenzl, representing the Austrian Empire. However, this treaty did not put an end to the German question. The treaty gave the French consent by Austria to annex the left bank of the Rhine, but the Treaty did not commit the Holy Roman Empire, which was not a party to the agreement.

A special congress was convened at Rastadt to settle difficulties arising from the treaty.[53] The Congress opened on 28 November 1797. In addition to France and Austria, 90 German states sent representatives. One issue to be settled was the manner in which the losses of the German princes caused by the French occupation of the left bank of the Rhine were to be compensated for by the secularization of almost all of the ecclesiastical Reichsstände. The Austrian Emperor had already agreed in secret articles to urge the estates to approve concessions on the left bank of the Rhine in exchange for Austrian possession of the archbishopric of Salzburg and a portion of Bavaria east of the Inn River which flows from West Austria into South Central Germany and South East Switzerland.

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[52] T.C.W. Blanning. *The French Revolution in Germany: Occupation and Resistance in the Rhineland, 1792-1802*. (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1983). 78.

[53] Ibid., 78-80.

The Germans were first induced to surrender the principle of the territorial integrity of the empire on 7 February 1798. They then had to agree to the surrender of the left bank of the Rhine on 9 March 1798. They further consented to secularization of the ecclesiastical estates to provide compensation to the lay princes on 4 April 1798. On 3 May 1798 the French demanded the surrender of key points on the right bank of the Rhine in order to secure their possessions on the left (a concession they did not receive). Austria had already agreed to many of these concessions in secret articles of Campo Formio.[54]

France was now the puppet-master of German affairs, a fact that had two direct consequences. First, it caused the dissolution of the "altes deutsches Reich", which had relied on the imperial church and the aristocracy outside the larger territories for its power and legal system. Secondly, unified medium sized states capable of supporting themselves were created or consolidated in the south and southwest by the enormous territorial expansion. Baden, Württemberg, Bavaria, Hesse-Darmstadt, and the Nassau principalities were the big winners in this reorganization (see figure 1 overleaf). Both the princes and the chief ministers of these states seized the opportunity for expansion with both hands, guided by an almost undiluted pragmatism, and allowing no legitimistic, patriotic or nationalist scruples to deter them.

These medium sized states now found themselves squeezed between the major German powers of Prussia and Austria, and they became fierce opponents of the old imperial structure. This was their first taste of genuine sovereignty, and they wanted no Kaiser or empire to negate that power. Individual states, which had aspired to full

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[54] Thomas Nipperdey. *Germany from Napoleon to Bismarck, 1800-1866*. trans. by Daniel Nolan. (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1996). 2.

sovereignty during the early modern era in the development of the German state, now attained their goal.[55] This new sovereignty, however, was not viable on its own, but relied on France for its political legitimacy and power. Since it was in the interests of Napoleonic France to uphold them, it was impossible for any other form of national organization of Germany, whether of the older or the newer variety. In this respect, the medium sized states were not simply a result of German history, but influenced by

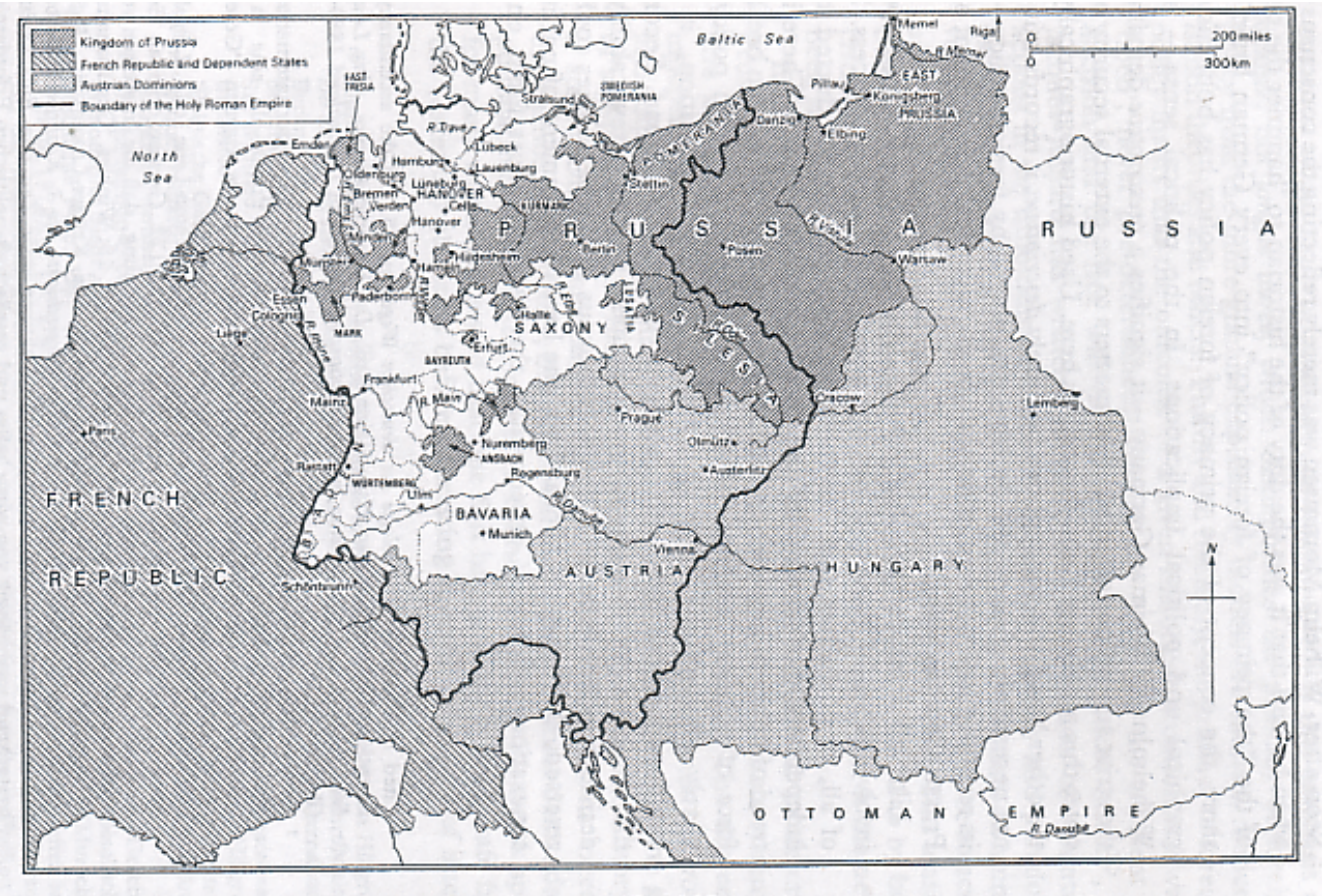

Figure 1: Central Europe in 1803.[56]

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[55] Ibid, 2.

[56] Brendan Simms. *The Impact of Napoleon: Prussian High Politics, Foreign Policy and the Crisis of the Executive, 1797-1806*. (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1996). 1.

France. First and foremost, they were the product of the policies through which Napoleon had sought to establish his hegemony. Thus, the pragmatism of the princes and ministers was inevitably linked to a need to fall into line with French policies.[57]

The Holy Roman Empire, which had become a loose confederation of sovereign states in 1648, was close to collapse after the major territorial changes wrought by France. Napoleon, whose ambitions caused Russia, Prussia, and Austria to be arrayed against him, tried to create a coalition of German states free from the influence of either Prussia or Austria. He succeeded in making allies of Baden and Württemberg, and keeping Prussia neutral, in the war of the Third Coalition,[58] which ended with the crushing French victory at Austerlitz. The Austro-Russian army was split in two and then destroyed with a loss of 27,000 men compared with 9,000 French casualties. While the Russians retreated to their homeland, Austria surrendered immediately and later ceded parts of Germany and Italy to France, in the peace treaty of Pressburg. This also enlarged Napoleon's allies and made them kings. Hanover was given to Prussia, while Austria lost almost all remaining possessions in Italy. These results caused a number of German states to abandon the Empire and form a new Confederation under Napoleon's protection and pledged to fight for him. This was the Confederation of the Rhine (*Rheinbund*), formed 12 July 1806. Initially composed of ten members, it was enlarged by 1808 to thirty, made up of almost all German states with the major exceptions of Austria and Prussia. On 1 August 1806 Napoleon ordered Francis II to

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[57] Ibid.

[58] Consisting of Britain, Austria, Russia, Sweden and some German states

relinquish the imperial crown of the Holy Roman Empire. By this act, on 6 August 1806, the Holy Roman Empire ended ignominiously after nine centuries.[59]

Austria's defeat at Austerlitz by Napoleon caused her subsequent removal from the Third Coalition. Because of this and sparked by France's growing arrogance towards her,[60] Prussia decided not to remain a French vassal and allied herself with the remnants of the Third Coalition. At the twin battles of Jena and Auerstadt, Prussia suffered not one, but two crushing defeats.[61] French troops marched through Berlin while her king sued for peace. Prussia was saved from complete destruction only through the intervention of the tsar who was anxious to preserve a buffer state between Russia and France. Even so, the Prussians lost all their territory west of the Elbe. This became the kingdom of Westphalia, ruled over by Napoleon's brother Jerome. Most of the Polish territories were incorporated in the grand duchy of Warsaw and handed over to the new King of Saxony, who was transformed into one of Napoleon's most devoted allies. Danzig became a free city guarded by a French garrison. In all, Prussia forfeited half her territory; and was saddled with a war indemnity of unknown proportions. The

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[59] Carr, 9.

[60] Napoleon completely surprised Prussia by forming the Confederation of the Rhine out of the south German states putting their forces under his command. Napoleon also refused to pull his forces out of Germany as he had agreed to do earlier. Also, France had offered Hanover to Britain, which she had earlier given to Prussia to gain Prussian support. Prussia tried to start a North German Confederation to balance out and compensate them for their losses, but this failed when France began to convince the other principalities not to join. See Schroeder *The Transformation of European Politics, 1763- 1848*. (Clarendon Press, 1994).

[61] Living off of dreams of past military conquests, the Prussians actually felt that they were more than a match for Napoleon's forces. The Prussian Royal Guard was so confident that before Austerlitz some of them sharpened their sabers on the steps of the French Embassy in Berlin. After the defeats of Jena and Auerstadt, the defeated Royal Guards who had performed the act of defiance were paraded through Berlin right past the French Embassy. See Marbot, Baron M. de. *Memories,* Vol. 1, ed. by General Koch, Paris, 1891. 234; Quoted in Chandler, David G. *The Campaigns of Napoleon.* (MacMillan Publishing Company: New York, 1966). 443, 500.

size of the Prussia army was strictly controlled[62] leaving her humiliated and reduced to a third rate power.[63]

The war debacle of 1806 demanded a drastic overhaul of Prussian society and the army. The Treaty of Tilsit had deprived her richest provinces and almost half her population. The only hope for regaining her former political and military position lay in harnessing all remaining resources. Political, economic, and military reform had to function hand-in-hand with reform of the body politic. The leaders of the political and military reform factions agreed to abolish feudal benefits and serfdom. This approach depended upon making citizen's service universal – not a burden, but a privilege of which to be proud. Conservative opposition and French intervention prevented the full implementation of these reforms.

Immediately, the forced reduction of the army to 42,000 men enabled the reformers to purge the officer corps. Between 1806 and 1808 of 125 generals, 17 had been cashiered, 86 honorably dismissed and only 22 retained on active duty, with similar reductions in the lesser grades.[64] Reorganization created the most important innovation - the concept of the modern German General Staff. If Napoleon was the last Great General of history, then Helmuth von Moltke was the first Great Manager of the modern military era. Moltke took command of the Prussian army in 1857 and rapidly built up a new system based on the principle of using highly trained and interchangeable staff

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[62] Carr, 9.

[63] All this was laid out in the Treaty of Tilsit (7-9 July 1807) which was signed between France and the Russo-Prussian alliance. Tsar Alexander I met Napoleon on a raft in the middle of the Nieman River, 25 June 1807 outside the town of Tilsit to negotiate the treaty. King Frederick William III was to meet the two leaders later to formalize the treaty. See Wawro. *Warfare and Society in Europe: 1792-1914*. (Routledge, 2000).

[64] Gunther Rothenberg. *The Napoleonic Wars.* (London: Cassell and Company, 1999). 174-175.

officers. These elite officers were trained in a war academy. Each year 120 young officers were selected from the whole officer corps on the basis of competitive examinations, of these, only about 40 finished the intensive scholastic course of the academy. And of these graduates, Moltke selected only the best 12 to be trained for the General Staff.[65]

The reformers hoped that the collective intelligence of highly trained staff officers would offset the past system; reliant on individual genius, and in 1810 opened a new school (later the War Academy) to instruct promising officers. In contrast to other armies where the chief of staff only implemented his commander's orders, the Prussian system envisaged the chief of staff as a full partner in command decisions.[66] This new army embodied and symbolized Prussian nationhood.[67]

Transformations in the Prussian military were not the only events occurring during this time. A levying of troops, a heavy tax burden and especially a Continental Blockade, as well as violent measures by the police and the occupying forces, the absence or delay of social reforms and an onerous bureaucracy, all contributed to the sharp rise in discontent with French rule.[68] Moreover, the defeatist attitude of the king and his establishment in the face of Napoleon's demands prompted many of the 'patriots' to give notice. About 500 officers resigned their commissions. Prominent

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[65] Michael Eliot Howard. *The Franco-Prussian War: the German Invasion of France*, 1870-1871. New York: Macmillan, 1961 and Walter Goerlitz. *History of the German General Staff, 1657-1945*. Trans. by Brian Battershaw. Westport, CT: Greenwood Press, 1975.

[66] Rothenberg, 174-175.

[67] May, 25.

[68] Nipperdey, 17.

officers Boyen and Clausewitz went to Russia. This reaction was a radical switch from loyalty to the king to loyalty to an abstraction – fatherland and nation.[69] The intellectual elite also began to demonstrate their opposition to Napoleonic tyranny. As modernists and nationalists, they rejected foreign rule in favor of the new 'fatherland'.[70] This rediscovery of a national identity, German history, and culture had a particular resonance in the territories of the Rhine. The resistance to Napoleon, desire for the independence of their own country and its liberation thus grew into a strong nationalistic patriotism. This switch from old provincial patriotism to a nationalist German patriotism spawned the German nationalist movement. It was precisely the opposition to dictatorship which mobilized the nationalist movement into a political and revolutionary movement. The patriots were mostly civil servants, army officers, and educated men, and the movement was centered in Prussia after 1806. Philosophers, journalist, and writers soon joined this core.[71] The desire for nationhood and national statehood became paramount. Idealistic philosophy and nationalistic patriotism converged. In 1808-09 the movement played an important role among journalist working in Berlin and Vienna. The romantic preoccupation with the identity of the Germans, their history, and culture also fed into this movement.[72] Secret societies and organizations promoting the ideologies of nationalism began to emerge.

After the disastrous 1812 Campaign in Russia, the remnants of Napoleon's Grande Armeé were eventually forced to abandon most of Prussia, including Berlin. In March

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[69] Ibid., 16.

[70] Ibid., 17.

[71] Ibid., 17-18.

[72] Ibid., 19.

1813, Prussia mobilized and declared war on France. Austria, although preparing for war, could not afford to risk another defeat and remained neutral throughout the spring and early summer. In response, Napoleon improvised a new conscript army of almost a half million French troops. Although they were inferior at marching and foraging, and were seriously short of cavalry (resulting from old army loses in Russia), his newly formed Army of the Main soon proved itself an effective fighting force. By May 1813, Napoleon assumed the offensive and quickly netted a pair of victories at Lutzen (near Leipzig) and Bautzen (between Dresden and Breslau). Nonetheless, by early summer, both combatants had been wasted by disease, attrition, and battle casualties. In June, the opposing force agreed to an armistice during which both sides hoped to reorganize and rebuild their forces. By August, the armistice came to an ominous end for France when Austria finally declared war. With almost 400,000 opposing troops in central Germany, Napoleon was now virtually surrounded by enemy armies - Austrians to the south, Russians to the east, Prussians and Swedish troops to the north. Soon, his German satellite forces began to waver and desert. Despite his worsening situation, the first battle of the new campaign resulted in a French victory at Dresden (August 26-27), which led to Napoleon's enemies adopting a new, effective strategy. For the next month, the Allies shunned battle against the Emperor and concentrated against the smaller forces lead by the French marshals. By October, Napoleon had fallen back to Leipzig and been surrounded by four separate opposing armies. The Battle of Leipzig[73] (October 16-19) became the largest battle of the Napoleonic Wars, as more than

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[73] Also known as the battle of Nations.

500,000 troops struggled over one bloody field.[74] By the third day Napoleon was decisively defeated. The remaining German satellite forces defected en masse as the French reeled back towards France. By the end of the year, the Napoleonic Empire had been reduced to France itself. Soon the German allies would soon be threatening Paris.

The war ended with capitulation of Paris in March of 1814, and the abdication of the throne of France by Napoleon on 6 April 1814. Guided by Metternich, the representatives of the European powers met at the Congress of Vienna from September 1814 to June 1815.[75] They redrew the map of Europe and laid the foundation for a long period of European peace. Almost in spite of the root cause of the wars, the peacemakers of 1815 were men who were backward looking and conservative, who were only concerned with putting right the mistakes and misdeeds of the past, that they themselves had witnessed, and fought against. They did not want a new Europe so much as a better version of the old one.[76]

In these circumstances, it is not surprising that the allies and peacemakers of 1815 paid little attention to nationalism when they considered Europe's future shape. Liberalism was given more scope in the form of constitutions, but there was absolute opposition to the idea of countries being ruled without a hereditary ruling family. The concept of a republic was synonymous with revolution, and none of them wanted to

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[74] At Leipzig the allies pitted 335,000 troops to the 190,000 troops of the French. See Gunther Rothenberg. *The Napoleonic Wars.* (London: Cassell and Company, 1999). 182.

[75] From 13 March to 22 June the Congress had to deal with the resurgence and defeat of Napoleon in the Hundred Days war. They did not adjourn; however, but continued on with the proceedings. Napoleon's defeat at Waterloo brought a final end to Napoleon and his republic.

[76] Chapman, 2.

garner trouble for the future.[77] The victor's now looked to strengthen their position by gaining territory, either in Europe or colonially, because a gain or re-gain of commonwealth meant power. Since all the great powers operated on this concept and were weary of each other, the possibility of conflict even after the defeat of France was great. They each had to be able to compromise and accept rival's claim's to territory. What was agreed to in 1815 was the need for a balance of power, which rested on the security of all five great powers.[78] Prussian foreign policy was simple: expressing little more than a desire for additional territory. This policy was born out of the need to surround itself with more area for protection from the other powers (particularly France) as it was from greed. However, because of Prussia's defeat in 1806, its negotiating position was not a strong one. It played a little part in the wars against Napoleon; nevertheless, it hoped to regain its lost territories. The Prussians believed that France should be punished severely, a view not held by all of the others.[79]

Another focus of the Congress was central Europe. It created a patchwork of very diminutive states, none of which had any substantial power. This assured that Germany remained weak. Termed the German Confederation, it was not as fragmented as the Holy Roman Empire but was more divided than the Confederation of the Rhine. Thus, the German Confederation was able to separate Austria and Prussia and also provide a buffer with France. Germans now had a national forum for discussion at Frankfurt, over

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[77] Ibid., 15.

[78] Ibid., 16.

[79] Ibid., 24.

which Austria presided, allowing suppression of nationalistic feelings that sprouted from any opposition or independent view of the settlement after 1815.[80]

Territorially, Prussia was the most successful of the great powers in 1815 as it accumulated sufficient territory to be counted properly as a great power rather than as an upstart German state. Through the Congress Prussia gained some Polish territory, Posen and Thorn, as well as about 40% of Saxony's population and 60% of its land area. Prussia also annexed the east bank of the River Rhine and a large proportion of the Kingdom of Westphalia, the total population of which amounted to some three million people which made up for the loss of as many Poles to the east. All of this was in accordance with the idea of having at least as much territory after 1815 as in 1805.[81]

With this sudden change in borders the Prussians began to realize the differences between the territories they lost and that they gained. They regretted losing so many compliant Polish serfs and being put in charge of so many Germans who had been exposed to twenty years of enlightened French rule and who before Catholic prelates had ruled.[82] Worse still, the Rhineland province was entirely separate from Prussia's other territories and also required Prussia to defend the Rhine River against a possible French attack. Prussia had still not solved its problem of having diffuse frontiers that were extremely difficult to defend.

No matter how geographically extended Prussia was, the territory that she had acquired held very fruitful in resources. The Rhineland became transformed into one of

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[80] Ibid., 41-42.

[81] Ibid., 49-50.

[82] Ibid., 50.

the foremost industrial zones in the world, and because it was not directly geographically attached it gave Prussia reason to close the territory between. Before doing this, Prussia developed a unified economic system in its own territories which it then extended, to its own advantage, to most of the Confederation. This became the Zollverein (the German Customs Union),[83] a free trade zone that unified the forerunner of Germany economically before any political union took place; it served as a template for a new German state as well as demonstrating to a reluctant population the lucrative advantages of forming a single country.[84] Prussia also completed a series of land swaps to secure Pomerania on the Baltic coast. It gave East Frisia to Hanover in return for Lauenburg which it then gave to Denmark in return for Pomerania. Altogether, through newly acquired territories and exchanges, Prussia's population doubled in 1815 from five to 10 million.[85]

Although the years after the Congress of Vienna saw a relative peace come over most of Europe, in less than ten years a series of revolutions began to threaten the peace of Europe, two in 1820 and more in 1830, and challenge the balance of power system that was established in 1815. The 1820 revolts involved both a nationalist uprising in Greece against Ottoman rule - a key step in gradually dismantling the

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[83] The German Customs Union actually began in 1818 when Prussia, seeing that the German Confederation would not attack the question of customs reform on a German-wide basis, integrated its provinces into a reformed and unified customs system, abolishing all internal customs barriers. In the 1820's, for political and economic reasons, a program was adopted to bring other independent German states into Prussia's customs system. To resist the Prussian union the South German states tried to form a customs union of their own, while some states in central and northern Germany tried to form a loose association called the Central German Commercial Union. These attempts failed and by 1833 all the German states had been amalgamated into a single German *Zollverein*. By 1836 the *Zollverein's* membership was up to 26 million inhabitants, a clear majority of the Bund. See Schroeder *The Transformation of European Politics, 1763-1848*. (Clarendon Press, 1994).

[84] Chapman, 50.

[85] Ibid.

Ottoman Empire in the Balkans - and a rebellion in Spain.[86] Revolutions in 1830 struck closer to Western European society. Another French rebellion brought in a change of kings when Charles X was forced to abdicate his throne in July of 1830. This resulted in a somewhat more liberal monarchy, though not producing a final balance among the conflicting ingredients of French politics. It also put all the powers of Europe on edge as remembrances of the Revolution of 1792 and its aftermath still resonated in the palaces of Europe. When Louis-Philipe, the Duke of Orleans, was installed as the new King of France in August of 1830[87] this seemed to quell the fear of another upheaval in Europe. The Revolution in France was just one of many revolutions that occurred in the 1830 timeframe. No sooner had things quieted down in France, then revolt erupted in Belgium over poor economic conditions and discontent over Orangist rule.[88] Risings also occurred in key states in Italy and Germany.

The Belgian Revolution of 1830 was a classic example of how new political forces could combine. The country had been placed under Dutch rule at the Congress of Vienna. Belgian nationalists, building on religious and language differences, found national independence an obvious target. Liberals chafed under Dutch restrictions on freedom of the press and teaching. Urban artisans sought new political rights, due to their worry about rapid commercial change, as Belgium began to develop factory production.[89] By 1830 the Belgians' patience had run out. Revolution erupted in

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[86] Schroeder, 614-628, 637-664.

[87] Alfred Cobban. *A History of Modern France.* (New York: George Braziller, 1965). 91-93.

[88] Schroeder, 670-691.

[89] Ibid.

Brussels and quickly spread across the country. William I made a brief effort to regain control, but within a few months he withdrew. As a result, on 20 January, 1831, after centuries of external rule, Belgium was recognized as an independent nation. The Belgians chose Leopold of Saxe-Coburg to be their first King, under a constitution that significantly limited the power of the monarchy. This apparent successful management of the Belgian question was clearly a great achievement in international politics. War was averted, treaties were peacefully revised, and a new, more viable intermediary body was substituted for one that had collapsed. The Belgian state that had emerged proved more viable than anyone could have predicted, and its constitutional development became a model for much of Europe.[90]

After being politically and socially repressed by Austria in the years following the Congress of Vienna in 1815, the German states were ripe for change. The July Revolution of 1830 provided just such an opportunity. In the southwestern constitutional states (Bavaria, Württemberg, Baden, Hesse-Darmstadt and Nassau) though revolution stimulated greater political activity, promoted calls for new constitutional reform, and in time promoted some radical agitation, no major change was ultimately produced. In northern and central Germany (Brunswick, Hanover, Electoral Hesse and Saxony) liberal/constitutional and worker/peasant uprisings occurred, and though the radical aspects of the movements were defeated, they led to compromise conservative/liberal constitutions in these states similar to those elsewhere.[91] Austria and Prussia remained relatively undisturbed by revolution and ultimately led a successful counter offensive on

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[90] Ibid., 691.

[91] Ibid., 700.

the federal level. Nonetheless, 1830-1832 dealt the Metternich system another blow, increasing the number of constitutional states, tipping the balance in Germany in their favor, and apparently proving that states with working representative constitutions could weather revolts better than those without.[92] The most important factor that emerged from these activities was the renewed attempts to create a Third Germany without Austria and Prussia. Prussia, realizing this began to change her policy towards the revolution from all out repression to more *laissez-faire,* thus seeking closer political ties with some of the middle states.

Through the 1830s the tides of revolution and the larger impact of new political movements had produced important changes in Western society in general as well as Germany. Regimes in France, Britain, Belgium, the United States, and several other countries led the way with; one, solid parliaments; two, at least some guarantees for individual rights against arbitrary state action; three, considerable religious freedom not only for various Christian sects but also for Jews; and four, universal male suffrage. Movements representing liberal and other political views had spread even more widely, operating as political parties in the liberalized states and as agitators in central Europe. Although the revolutionary sequence had not ended - a major outburst was still to come in 1848 - this movement it had already begun to interact with the other great Western transformation, the rise of industrialization.

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[92] Ibid.

Three years of economic depression and crop failures, coupled with the political frustration felt by liberal middle-class and nationalistic groups, precipitated a series of revolutions across Europe in rapid succession during 1848.[93]

The first outbreak occurred on February 22 in Paris, driving Louis Philippe from his throne and bringing in a provisional government dedicated to a democratic franchise and "national workshops" to reduce unemployment. The election of a French national assembly, however, brought to Paris provincial deputies who opposed the workshops. The result was a working-class uprising in June that was crushed with considerable bloodshed. The national assembly, dominated by the middle class, went on to establish the Second Republic with a democratically elected legislature and executive. In December Louis Napoleon was elected president.[94]

In Vienna, capital of the Austrian Empire, the news from Paris inspired popular demonstrations that drove the conservative minister Metternich from office. A sequence of German liberal reform ministries followed, however, the other nationalities within the Austrian Empire wished to control their own affairs.[95] On March 5, Hungary gained autonomy and drafted a constitution. In turn the Croats, organized at Zagreb, to seek freedom from Hungary. In Italy, where the expulsion of Austria had long been the goal of the Italian unity movement (*Risorgimento*), a Venetian republic was proclaimed, and

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[93] A. J. P. Taylor. *The Struggle for the Mastery in Europe: 1848-1918*. (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1971). 4-5.

[94] Ibid., 24-25.

[95] Schroeder, 796.

a revolution in Milan (March 18-22) was promptly supported by a new liberal regime in Sardinia-Piedmont.[96]

By June, the Czechs organized a Pan-Slav Congress in Prague to demand equality with the Germans. On June 17, Austrian forces crushed this rebellion and a month later regained control in Milan. Then a constituent assembly convened in Vienna to draft a constitution for the Austrian Empire. It succeeded in abolishing serfdom, but in October the assembly itself was driven from Vienna by a working-class rebellion and a new prime minister, Felix Schwarzenberg, later repudiated its work. In December, the young Francis Joseph succeeded Ferdinand I as emperor of Austria and imposed a severely centralized administration. The Hungarians, declared their independence from Austria in April 1849. Schwarzenberg then called in the Russian army, and in August the Hungarians surrendered. That summer a Roman republic created by Giuseppe Mazzini and Giuseppe Garibaldi collapsed, and the Austrian forces recaptured Venice.[97]

In Germany the Paris revolution also inspired unrest. A bloody confrontation in Berlin (15-21 March) forced the Prussian king Frederick William IV to summon a constitutional assembly. This example was followed in other German states. Principally, however, the liberals hoped to create a unified German empire, and to this end the Frankfurt Parliament was elected and convened (18 May). It adopted a bill of rights and a moderately democratic form of government. However, when Schwarzenberg made clear his determination to centralize Austria, the Frankfurt Parliament decided to exclude the German-speaking provinces of Austria from the German empire and in

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[96] Taylor, *The Struggle for the Mastery in Europe: 1848-1918*, 17-23.

[97] Ibid., 21-36.

March 1849 offered the crown of a constitutional Germany to the King of Prussia Frederick William IV.[98] He declined, but later tried to obtain it by the free agreement of the German princes. Frederick reversed the process by dissolving the constituent assembly and imposing his own constitution, which favored the wealthy classes but gave Prussia a measure of parliamentary government. Despite a few lasting gains, the Revolutions of 1848 resulted in severe defeats for liberal nationalists seeking democratic reform.[99]

Even though the liberal nationalist suffered defeat in the revolutions of 1848, the core messages of revolution were clear throughout Europe. Economic, social, and political reforms were essential or the consequences would be more revolt that would ultimately succeed. Unification in Germany was another matter. If Prussia or any other German state was to make a move towards unification, they needed to do it promptly. Also toward that end, other powers needed to abandon meddling in German affairs as had been routine since the fall of Rome. Furthermore, for the unification of Germany to evolve and succeed, there needed to be a strong leader that would be forceful within and diplomatic enough to weather the other powers' complaints and intimidation. That leader would come, not in a King but in a Chancellor, and he would rearrange Germany and Europe into what it is today.

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[98] Ibid., 35-36.

[99] Ibid., 36.

I have never lived on principles. When I have had to act, I never first asked myself on what principles I was going to act, but I went at it and did what I thought fit. I have often reproached myself for my want of principle.

Prince Otto von Bismarck-Schonhausen

Chapter II

Bismarck

The year 1815 was very crucial in European history. It was a year in which Napoleon Bonaparte escaped from the island of Elba, tried to establish France as the superpower on the continent again and was defeated by the combined forces of Britain and Prussia at Waterloo on June 15th. It was a year in which the major powers of Europe got together at the Congress of Vienna to come up with a balance of power system that would enable many years of relative peace in Europe. It was also a year in which the birth of a very significant person in European history can only be looked upon as a footnote. On 1 April 1815 as the allied forces gathered for the final campaign against Napoleon, Otto von Bismarck was born on the estate of Schonhausen in Brandenburg.[100]

Prince Otto Eduard Leopold von Bismarck-Schonhausen also known as the Iron Chancellor has been considered one of the greatest and most dynamic statesmen of the 19th century. He sprang to prominence in the revolution of 1848 as a man of the extreme right. He and his associates among the Prussian conservatives wanted to defeat the revolution and restore the absolutist monarchy that had existed in Prussia and most of Europe before 1848. In this they were largely successful, but the defeat of the liberals was not complete or irrevocable. From 1849 onwards Prussia had a semi-constitutional regime under which executive power remained with the King and the

[100] Otto Pflanze. *Bismarck and the Development of Germany: The Period of Unification 1815-1871.* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1963). 49.

ministers appointed by him, but with strictly limited legislative and taxing powers vested in an elected parliament.[101]

Bismarck was duly rewarded for the role he had played as one of the leading younger men of the conservative faction in the stormy years from 1848 to 1850. In 1851 he was appointed Prussian envoy to the diet of the German Confederation in Frankfurt. It was a key post in the making of Prussian policy, especially in relation to the future shape of Germany. The attempts to establish either Grossdeutschland (Germany including Austria) or Kleindeutschland (Germany without Austria led by Prussia) had failed during the years of revolution and in 1850 the Confederation of nearly 40 German states called into being in 1815 was simply revived. Austria, as the premier "German" country, resumed the presidency. In the eight years he spent in Frankfurt between 1851 and 1859, Bismarck began to see clearly that this revived Confederation had no future. It proved impossible to restore the cooperation of the three conservative powers, Austria, Russia and Prussia, which, linked to the personal ascendancy of the Austrian chancellor Metternich, had until 1848 dominated the Confederation and Europe as a whole.[102] It became Bismarck's overriding preoccupation in Frankfurt to counteract Austria's attempt to continue her leading role in Germany and to assert Prussia's right to equality. Towards the end of his time in Frankfurt, Bismarck also began to change his views about German nationalism. He had often in his letters referred to it contemptuously as `the nationality swindle', but now he thought that the German nationalist movement could be manipulated in the interests of enhancing Prussian power. The middle-class

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[101] Edgar Feuchtwanger. "Bismarck, Prussia and German Nationalism." *History Review.* (March 2001). 14.

[102] Ibid., 14.

liberals who were the mainstay of the German national movement might become useful allies of the monarchy and the aristocracy. As the events of 1848 had shown, they were as afraid of the masses as were the aristocracy.[103]

In 1862 King Wilhelm I of Prussia chose Bismarck to serve as his Minister-President. As Germany's first chancellor, a post he was to hold for thirty years, Bismarck was able to mold a scattering of principalities into a nation. He was brought in by Wilhelm I to direct Prussia's government in the face of the Prussian parliament's refusal to pass a budget because it disagreed with the army reforms desired by the King and his military advisers.[104] Bismarck's appointment was arguably one of the great turning points in history. He now proceeded along the lines he had foreshadowed in the innumerable letters and reports, which he had showered upon monarch, ministers and courtiers in Berlin during his time as a diplomat.[105] His critical qualities were put to full use in the first years after becoming Minister-President and Foreign Minister of Prussia. He inherited a diplomatic service, which, although Frederick William I had founded it, enjoyed little prestige in the country. This was due partly to military traditions of the Prussian state, where it was infinitely more glamorous to wear the King's coat than to compose dispatches. It was also due to the timid and vacillating nature of Prussian foreign policy during the first sixty years of the nineteenth century, which was hardly designed to attract spirited and talented young men. The Prussian Foreign Service was

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[103] Ibid., 14.

[104] Hajo Holborn. *A History of Modern Germany: 1840-1945,* (New York: A.A. Knopf Inc., 1969) 152-153.

[105] Feuchtwanger, 14.

in a sorry state in 1862--disorganized, undisciplined, and destitute of either uniform method or clear channels of communication.[106]

Bismarck was gifted at judging political forces and sizing up a situation: he recognized that conservatives would have to come to terms with other social groups if they were to continue to direct Prussian affairs. He was also a tactician skilled and ruthless enough to govern without parliament's consent from 1862 to 1866. Only on the condition that the Prussian monarchy would preserve its traditional character was Bismarck willing to accept a reform of the Germanic Confederation. No doubt, he contemplated early on the enhancement of power which might accrue to Prussia if she gained direct leadership in Germany, or at least in North Germany. It became clear to Bismarck that such gains could be won only on European battlefields.[107] What he now hoped to do was to make progress on the German question through a Prussian policy of strength and thereby to reconcile the Prussian liberals to the uncompromising stand of the King on the question of military control. Bismarck worked his way, in the next eight years, through masterly diplomacy and the prowess of the Prussian armies, to sensational triumphs. What had triumphed, however, was not German nationalism, let alone liberalism, but the Prussian military monarchy and with it Bismarck himself. Against the odds and in defiance of the spirit of the age, a semi-authoritarian system was perpetuated and foisted on the whole of Germany. What Bismarck had helped set up was a complicated balance between monarchical and parliamentary power, between federalism and unitary control, which rendered Bismarck himself virtually indispensable

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[106] Gordon A Craig. *From Bismarck to Adenauer: Aspects of German Statecraft*. (Baltimore: The Johns Hopkins Press, 1958). 4-5.

[107] Holborn. 152-153.

as the only man who could master the system. In foreign affairs, too, he was a man who stood between the old-fashioned cabinet diplomacy that had controlled affairs in the past and the new-fangled intrusion of public opinion and the press, of what has been called the political mass market. The three wars he unleashed in 1864, 1866 and 1870 were limited wars with limited objectives, such as Europe had always been accustomed to in the past to adjust power relations.[108]

Bismarck's contributions to the unification of Germany have been everlasting. Although the boundaries of Germany have changed after two world wars and the Cold War, Germany as a nation, a concept and a people have been unchanged. In fact it was during the Cold War that the German people actually reflected the spirit that Bismarck had hoped to attain. Divided at the end of World War II by the political ideologies of communism and democracy, the East and West Germans still maintained their identities and the fervent hope that one day Germany would be whole again. When the Berlin wall was torn down in 1989, the German nation was brought together once again like it had been after the Franco-Prussian War.

But where did the influences that made Bismarck the man he was to develop into come from? Was it his heritage, parents, religion or the political confusion of the times that influenced Bismarck? What about his intelligence or his flexibility? Where did these traits come from? In the following pages we will take a look at the people and events that influenced Bismarck. We will also be looking at where certain traits came from that made him the diplomat and statesman that he was.

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[108] Feuchtwanger, 14.

On his father's side, Bismarck came from a long line of Junkers, the landowning aristocracy of the Prussian provinces east of the Elbe. A Junker was a nobleman, and as a rule, a great landowner. His status as a nobleman was expressed by the preposition “von” before his name. The usage of “von” before the name was not only of social but also of legal importance, especially from the reign of Frederick the Great onwards. King Frederick’s declared policy was to keep the landed estates, significantly called *Ritterguter* (estates of the Knights), in the hands of the Junkers, and to recruit army officers exclusively from their ranks “because”, as he wrote, “the sons of the nobility defend the country and their race is so good, that they should be preserved in every way”. By the time of Bismarck’s birth these privileges had been abolished by law but not in practice. In point of fact, no commissions in the Prussian army, especially in the crack regiments of the guards or the cavalry, went to any other man than a nobleman.[109] The nobleman was also the administrative head of the municipally run community and exercised jurisdiction over its inhabitants. Thus the young Bismarck grew up at his father’s country estate among people accustomed to accept the rule, even the dictatorship of the nobleman, and who regarded every member of his family as a born master.[110]

The Hohenzollerns, a royal dynasty originally from South Germany, had from the seventeenth century taken the Junkers into their service, mainly in the army, and had by this and other means built their scattered territories into a major European power. Many

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[109] Erich Eyck. *Bismarck and the German Empire.* (New York: The Norton Library, 1964). 11-12.

[110] Feuchtwanger, 14.

of Bismarck's paternal forebears had, besides running their estates, served as generals in the Prussian army.[111]

Politically the Junkers were invariably of one mind. They were strictly conservative, fervent enemies of reforms, and strict upholders of their own legal, material, or social privileges. They were ardent Royalists, but on the understanding that the King would maintain their old privileges and prerogatives, especially the preferential promotion in the army and the administration.[112] The King knew what he possessed in his Junkers while of course the Junkers knew how valuable the King was to them.[113] It was this class that Bismarck considered himself a member of; in 1848 he said to a Liberal member of parliament with whom he was on friendly terms: ”I am a Junker and want to profit from it”. But he belonged to the nobility only on his paternal side.[114]

Bismarck’s mother, Wilhelmine, was not of noble descent, but came from middle-class stock. She was simply Wilhelmine Mencken, the daughter of a high official, trusted by King Frederick William III. She had a well-defined outlook on many questions such as the purpose of human existence, the moral obligations it involved and on education.[115] Her father, Ludwig Mencken, came from a long line of professors of jurisprudence and practical jurists, from the Leipzig area of central Germany. The office of *Kabinettsrat* (liaison between the monarch and certain departments), which Mencken held, was highly respected and enabled him to participate directly in the conduct of

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[111] Ibid., 12.

[112] Ibid., 12.

[113] Werner Richter. *Bismarck.* trans. Brian Battershaw. (New York: Putnam, 1965). 24.

[114] Eyck, 12

[115] Ibid., 13.

public affairs. His physical appearance showed him to be the offspring of a race of highly bred intellectuals. In so far as it was possible for a Prussian official, Mencken was influenced by the ideas of the French Revolution.[116] In fact, Bismarck says of his mother and grandfather:

> My mother was the daughter of Mencken, Privy Councillor to Frederick the Great, Frederick William II, and Frederick William III, who sprang from a family of Leipzig professors, and was accounted in those days a Liberal. The later generations of the Menckens-those immediately preceding me-had found their way to Prussia in the Foreign Office and about the Court. Baron von Stein has quoted my grandfather Mencken as an honest, strongly Liberal official. Under these circumstances, the views which I imbibed with my mother's milk were Liberal rather than reactionary; and if my mother had lived to see my ministerial activity, she would scarcely have been in accord with its direction, even though she would have experienced great joy in the external results of my career. She had grown up in bureaucratic and court circles; Frederick William IV spoke of her as 'Mienchen,' in memory of childish games. I can therefore declare it an unjust estimate of my views in my younger years, when 'the prejudices of my rank' are thrown in my teeth and it is maintained that a recollection of the privileges of the nobility has been the starting-point of my domestic policy.[117]

Bismarck never had a good word for his mother, because to him she lacked unselfish motherly love and she interfered too much with his wishes. Nevertheless, he inherited from his mother not only his very sensitive nerves, but also his vitality and superior intelligence.[118] Much of his character can also be traced back to his mother's influence. His resistance to schooling and later his unwillingness to apply himself to his studies represent his answer to her ambitions. Instead of hiring a tutor, which was customary among noble families, she sent him away from his accustomed surroundings to a town

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[116] Richter, 24-25.

[117] Prince Otto von Bismarck. *Bismarck: The Man and the Statesman*, *Vol. I*. ed. Horst Kohl, trans. A. J. Butler. (London: Harper and Brothers Publishers, 1898). 16-17.

[118] Eyck, 13.

school “in order to break his aristocratic pride”.[119] Bismarck never seems to have gotten over this. Throughout his whole life he never lost a dislike for his mother and also of the whole social stratum from which she came, namely the higher bureaucracy. Yet, whether he wished it or not, he received certain endowments from the Mencken family which did more to shape the course of his life than the half-peasant inheritance from his father. His wealth of ideas, capacity for extricating himself from any difficulty and his razor sharp intellect may be described as inherited characteristics. Inherited as well was the lightening speed with which he could grasp a situation and the unerring instinct with which he reacted to it especially where the interpretation of a law or an agreement was concerned. Also inherited was that cold bureaucratic indifference with which he ignored everything that was unlucky enough to stand in his way.[120]

Bismarck was never known as a religiously devout man. In his childhood he had not received any firm religious foundation. His father was not very religious and never spoke with Bismarck on the subject. His mother was raised in the rationalist tradition and was not a churchgoer.[121] Because of this, Bismarck constantly struggled to maintain the faith that he had acquired in his youth.[122] In this time of turmoil Bismarck would debate religious questions with two devout Pomeranian neighbors and close friends, Moritz von Blanckenburg and his fiancée Marie von Thadden. It was Marie who introduced Bismarck to Johanna von Puttkamer, his future wife. Both women worked diligently for his conversion. However, it was after Marie’s death in 1846 that Bismarck

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[119] Richter, 25.

[120] Ibid., 25-26.

[121] Pflanze, *Bismarck and the Development of Germany: The Period of Unification 1815-1871,* 52.

[122] Craig, 19.

fully converted. From the day of her death on, prayer and devotion became an integral part of his existence. He wrote a letter to Johanna's father in December 1846 declaring his religious conversion and love for Johanna.[123] The religious revival Bismarck now adhered to had begun as a lay movement within the Lutheran church. The movement sought to achieve a sense of union with God. They rejected the rational, unemotional element, which had penetrated the clergy during the enlightenment. In place of reason they emphasized feeling; for theology they substituted divine and brotherly love.[124] This was how Bismarck led his religious life. He rarely went to church and cared little for ministry and pastoral sermons. His devotion was limited to daily prayer, Bible reading and the daily verses of the Moravian Brethren. While influenced by the Lutheran tradition, Bismarck's faith was essentially untheological. The religious devotion gave Bismarck personal orientation and a sense of purpose that he had previously lacked. However, he did not find in religion a doctrinal basis for his politics[125] that was to come from people and events he encountered.

When Bismarck left school in 1832 he says that he was a normal product of the Prussian state system of education. He was a Pantheist[126] and if not a Republican, at least secure in the fact that the Republic was the most rational form of government. He could not understand what caused millions of men to obey one man.[127] It is also here that Bismarck got his first taste of the "German-National" impression that would guide

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[123] Pflanze, *Bismarck and the Development of Germany: The Period of Unification, 1815-1871,* 53-54.

[124] Ibid, 54.

[125] Ibid, 55.

[126] Tolerant of other people's religious beliefs.

[127] Bismarck, *Bismarck: The Man and the Statesman*, Vol. I. 1.

him for the rest of his career. But while these impressions did cause young Bismarck to question the direction of the society for which he lived, they were not strong enough to completely override his innate Prussian monarchial sentiment.[128] In fact, it was during his college years that Bismarck's political leanings truly begin to reveal themselves. Bismarck joined a group of students who made the promotion of a national sentiment their aim, but he quit after being disillusioned by what he calls their "Utopian theories and defective breeding".[129] Mainly what disenchanted Bismarck is the total lack of respect for the monarchy. The rippling effects of the revolutions of 1830 began to transform Bismarck even more. He regarded the rising up of the people as repulsive. He became angry over land lost to France in the Wars of Liberation. It is also during this time (before 1848) that Bismarck began to see himself joining the diplomatic corps. He saw people like Pommer-Esche and Delbruck as model leaders on the official road. Bismarck began his diplomatic career in 1847 in the United Diet as a partisan champion of conservative interest. He opposed any measures or reforms that were meant to cause the aristocratic class any type of sacrifice, whether introduced by the crown or the liberal opposition. The revolution of 1848 saw Bismarck play a crucial role in Prussian politics. When Bismarck heard of the uprising he armed the villagers of Schonhausen and hastened to Potsdam to promote a counterrevolution by the army backed by the peasantry.[130] The generals however, refused to act without the King's command. When the King bowed to the wishes of the revolutionaries, Bismarck was disheartened. In the ensuing months the new Parliament began to institute reforms that would

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[128] Ibid, 1.

[129] Ibid, 2.

[130] Pflanze, *Bismarck and the Development of Germany: The Period of Unification 1815-1871,* 62.

invariably begin to push the Junkers out of power. In August of 1848, Bismarck joined in the "Junker Parliament" which basically organized the nobility for the defense of their interests.[131] Bismarck believed that the privileges of his caste were earned through centuries of service to Prussia. It was these privileges that he would fight to protect for the rest of his life. When the King finally decided to use force the revolution quickly came to an end but Bismarck never forgot the lessons he learned. Throughout the rest of his career Bismarck's first purpose in domestic politics was to preserve monarchial control over the means of exercising force.[132]

As we can see, Bismarck was a very complex man. The person he despised the most, his mother, is the one person from whom he received the most in the way of intellect and personal drive. Religion basically orientated young Bismarck and gave him direction. His political leanings were actually honed through the schools he attended and the political changes of the time. For Bismarck, these attributes and lessons made him a stronger man with more conviction than most to do what needed to be done to preserve the monarchy and more importantly his way of life. They also brought to light the German-Nationalistic fervor that would, in later years, become the nucleus of his drive to create a unified Germany with Prussia at its head.

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[131] Ibid, 65.

[132] Ibid, 66.

The great questions of the day will not be settled by means of speeches and majority decisions, but by iron and blood.

Prince Otto von Bismarck-Schonhausen

Chapter III

German Unification and the Shift in the European Order

In August of 1914, Europe erupted into war, a war that had not been seen since the days of Napoleon Bonaparte, and a war that was one of the most violent and destructive wars in European history. Of the 65 million men who were mobilized, more than 10 million were killed and more than 20 million wounded. It was the first European total war. Once the war began, the countries involved mobilized their entire populations and economic resources to achieve victory on the battlefield. This World War forever changed the makeup of Europe and marked the end of European hegemony. The causes of the collapse of the traditional "balance of power" system, intact since the 1815 Congress of Vienna, were the dramatic changes in the five great powers: England, Russia, Austria, Prussia, and France. Prussia was now a part of Imperial Germany since the Three Wars of Unification in the mid 1800's; Austria was now part of the dual monarchy of Austria-Hungary. England and France in the Crimean War had humiliated Russia. Further, France had had another Napoleon on the throne. Italy had also unified, from the kingdoms of Sardinia and the Two Sicilies, the Papal States, and the duchies of Tuscany, Parma, Modena and Romagna, adding additional power to the mix.[133] Although England had managed to keep herself isolated from the continent she still went through enormous economic, social, and political changes over the intervening hundred years.

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[133] Aristotle Kallis. "Expansionism in Italy and Germany between Unification and the First World War." *European History Quarterly,* 28: 4 (October 1998). 438.

There are multiple reasons for the collapse of the balance of power system. France and England blamed Germany for upsetting the balance of power and starting the war. Woodrow Wilson blamed the entangling alliances and secret treaties of the decades previous that caused the eventual breakdown and start of the war. Some scholars have argued that it was the slow death of the Ottoman Empire that was the cause. Numerous scholars have argued that it was the failed foreign policies of all the nations involved. Others have argued that it was Germany's sudden unification and rise to power. However, it was not Bismarck's intention to upset the balance of power system, either advertently or inadvertently, while creating a unified German nation. He appeared to make great efforts and took actions to keep the balance intact while bringing Germany together. Bismarck knew that a fledgling Germany could not survive the combined efforts of all the other powers in either a fragmented state or adversarial role, so he worked, through diplomatic maneuverings, alliances and small wars to bring all the German states together under Prussian rule. In the following pages we will see how Bismarck deftly worked the unification of Germany issue without upsetting the balance of power thus keeping the concert of Europe intact. We will discuss the German wars of unification, European reaction to them and the diplomatic maneuverings that they entailed.

After the Napoleonic Wars in 1814-15 all the major states in Europe met in Vienna to draw up a peace settlement. The four main allies, England, Russia, Austria, and Prussia, which were the main forces who had defeated Napoleon, attended this meeting, which was known as the Congress of Vienna. Most of the remaining countries sent delegates to attend the congress. The Congress of Vienna is hailed as one of the

most important meetings in European history. It set the boundaries of some nations and abolished the boundaries of others. At the congress the great powers of the Fourth Coalition each looked to strengthen their own position by the acquisition of territory either in Europe or colonially. Some rulers of smaller countries, defeated by Napoleon, were given their thrones back. Others were not. The conference also set out the way defeated France was supposed to be treated by the others, and the fate of some of the French colonies around the world.[134]

The most important thing to come out of the congress; however, was the agreement for a need of some sort of system to balance nationalistic power after the above adjustments were made. The negotiators at Vienna went through enormous efforts to balance territory, resources, and population as equitably as possible among the major powers. Basically balancing Russian gains in Poland against Austrian gains in Italy and Prussian acquisitions in the Rhineland. They built buffers between the great powers in the Low Countries and in the German states that lay between Prussia and Austria. This elaborate redrawing of the map of Europe was intended to keep the large scale, devastating wars like the Napoleonic Wars from happening again.[135] But the balance of power system was not just about redrawing the map of Europe: it was also about working together to keep peace. Within its codes, single states could not increase their possessions without the consent of the other states, if a single state did begin to get too powerful, then the other states would band together to bring them back into line.

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[134] Chapman, 1-2.

[135] Gordon A. Craig and Alexander L. George. *Force and Statecraft: Diplomatic Problems of Our Time.* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1995). 26.

Regardless of the intent of the Congress and the resulting balance of power concept, the revolutions of 1848 signaled the end of respect and established order, both at home and in foreign affairs. Yet the existing system survived the revolutions and even transformed their nationalistic impulse into a new prop for the continuation of the concept of balance of power.[136] Except for the Crimean War there were only minor clashes that were handled without the full intervention of all the powers. Even the Crimean War did not involve all of Europe; however, but had all of the European countries attention in case it did escalate.

In 1815 Russia appeared the strongest single power on the continent, followed closely by the Austrians. After 1848 she seemed to have outdistanced the other land powers: Russian primacy had turned into Russian domination. The Crimean War was confined to comparatively small areas, and the forces engaged were small in relation to the available manpower of the belligerents (Russia vs. France, England).[137] The defeat of Russia by the others changed Russia's position in Europe for nearly a hundred years. The Crimean War reduced Russia to one among several Great powers allowing in the next few years France, and even Austria to be her equals. After 1870 the new German Empire was her superior.[138] However, Russia was not the only country to go through changes. There were other changes, than war, on the way that would test the balance of power system. Austria, France, England, Italy, and Prussia would all go through major upheavals and policy changes. It was the changes that would involve Prussia

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[136] Taylor, *The Struggle for the Mastery in Europe:1848-1918*, xxii.

[137] Geoffrey Wawro. *The Austro-Prussian War: Austria's War With Prussia and Italy in 1866*. (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1996). 10-11.

[138] Hugh Seton-Watson. *The Russian Empire: 1801-1917.* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1967). 331.

and her dynamic Chancellor Otto von Bismarck that would forever change the map of Europe and test the concert of Europe.

Otto von Bismarck was chosen to serve as minister president of Prussia by King Wilhelm I in 1862. Bismarck was a tactician skilled and ruthless enough to govern without the Prussian parliament's consent from 1862 to 1866. He was willing to accept a reform of the Germanic Confederation only on the condition that the Prussian monarchy would preserve its traditional character. No doubt, he contemplated the enhancement of power which might accrue to Prussia if she gained direct leadership in Germany, or at least in North Germany. Although he knew that such gains could be won only on European battlefields, it was not his purpose to jeopardize the fundamental order of Europe. Regardless of the ultimate political consequences of the founding of the new German Empire, Bismarck never intended to cripple the European state system by the destruction of any of its constituent members. If he wanted to bring about a shift in the balance of power in Europe in favor of Prussia, or of a Germany led by Prussia, this was to be achieved within the framework of the traditional family of European states. Bismarck was aware that to upset the balance of power would put all of Europe against the fledging German nation; and this was a battle that Germany would not survive intact. Bismarck was not a democratic nationalist and, therefore, not one to believe in national self-determination. He never faced war lightly and he continuously condemned preventive wars, but he did accept war as inherent in the nature of the world and consequently as a proper means for accomplishing his own political aims.[139]

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[139] Holborn, 152-153.

The three wars of German unification play a crucial part in outlining Bismarck's goal of a German nation. At first it looked as if Prussia was trying to simply gobble up territory in order to become a nation; however, upon closer scrutiny, an intricate plan emerges that was put into effect from 1863 to 1871. This plan involved all of Europe, but only four countries directly. The main goal of this plan is to get Austria out of the German Confederation in order to unite all the rest of Germany. However, Bismarck wanted to have Austria apart from the German states in such a way that he would be able to have them as an ally later on if needed. It is within this process that Bismarck showed his mastery of politics and diplomacy. In the Schleswig-Holstein problem, he was able to maneuver Austria into a foreign policy position that helped him in 1864 and that he exploited in 1866, while at the same time acquiring three German territories from the Danish. He did all this without upsetting the balance of power in Europe.

It is in 1864 that the face of Europe is forever changed. It is the first time since the Congress of Vienna in 1814, that two European Powers (Austria and Prussia) jointly disrupt the tranquility of Europe to start a war on behalf of a German cause against a non-German power.[140] It is here that Bismarck sees his first opportunity to implement his plan of German unification by turning the Schleswig-Holstein problem to his advantage.

The duchies of Schleswig-Holstein, which are located in the northern part of Germany on the Danish peninsula (see figure 2 overleaf), had been associated with each other since the late Middle Ages when the council of the local nobility, anxious to prevent fresh partitions of the duchies, agreed to elect as their ruler Christian of

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[140] Henry Kissinger. *Diplomacy.* (New York: Simon and Schuster, 1994) 112.

Oldenburg, the King of Denmark. Recognizing the position of privilege of the local nobility, King Christian signed the Charter of 1460 in which he acknowledged that he was ruler not by hereditary right but by election. He also proclaimed that only his male heirs would be eligible for election as duke. It is because of this charter that the duchies were able to hold their close association with Denmark and their distinctive social and political structure, largely German, for over 300 years.[141] Despite the looseness of the political and economic links binding the duchies to Denmark, loyalty to the Danish crown was strong enough to help them survive the trauma of 1814 when Denmark, an ally of Napoleon, suffered defeat. The King's German subjects remained as loyal to the crown as did his Danish subjects.[142] In fact it was not until 1840 that national animosities affected the relationship between Germans and Danes and the Schleswig area was at the heart of the dispute.

The Duchies of Schleswig-Holstein touched upon several passionate political sentiments of the times, especially nationalism and ethnic politics.[143] The duchies, although treated as one, were actually very different from each other in culture, language and economic status. Holstein was completely German speaking had been a member of the Holy Roman Empire and was admitted without question to full membership of the German Confederation in 1815.[144] The King of Denmark, as Duke of Holstein had a seat in the Federal Diet. Schleswig, on the other hand, had never been in the Holy Roman Empire and was not a member of the Confederation. The

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[141] Carr, 35-36.

[142] Ibid., 36.

[143] Arden Bucholtz, *Moltke and the German Wars: 1864-1871*. (New York: Palgrave, 2001). 79-80.

[144] Carr, 34-35

language of state in Schleswig and Holstein was High German, but at least half the population of Schleswig spoke a Danish dialect. It was these differences that were at the heart of the problems in the 1830's and 1840's.

Figure 2: Location of Schleswig-Holstein on the Danish Peninsula[145]

With the defeat of Napoleon in 1815, Europe was inclined to return to the pre French Revolution days of monarchial control. However, one of the consequences of the revolution was the rise in cultural awareness. The populations began to question

[145] Bucholtz, 82.

behavioral and structural norms that had been in place for hundreds of years. In the duchy of Schleswig this enlightenment was particularly fervent. Although they were a component of Denmark, High German was spoken in all the government jobs and offices, rather than the expected Danish. King Christian VIII tried to integrate this area by making Danish the official language in the courts, schools and churches of North Schleswig calculating that by giving limited recognition to the nationalistic movement in Schleswig he would retain the loyalty of that duchy. However, this plan backfired, as German officials and landowners owned most of the estates in Schleswig and became convinced that the king and the liberals were plotting to separate Schleswig from Holstein, which was not his intention at all. Conversely, the Danish liberals also assumed incorrectly that because the Germans would not concede to Danish equality status that the Germans wished to separate the duchies from Denmark.[146] This issue though was just the straw that broke the proverbial camels back and led to the events of 1848. The real and most controversial issue was the issue of succession.

The original Charter of 1460 between the King of Denmark and the local nobility stated that only the King's male heirs could be the Duke of Schleswig and Holstein. While there had not been any treaties since the Charter of 1460 that would alter this charter, some legal opinions had it that the Charter of 1460 did not apply to the Gottorp parts of Schleswig since they had been annexed to Denmark. In the event of a King dying with no male heir, Schleswig could be ruled by a female successor while Holstein would separate and be ruled by someone else entirely. The duchies did not like this situation at all. It is alleged that they formed an independent state that would be ruled

[146] Carr, 37.

by the male heir of the royal house. They took the position that when this line was extinct then the link with Denmark became terminated. They demanded, in 1846, that King Christian VIII negotiate with the Federal Diet to secure Schleswig's appointment into the German Confederation. The King responded with a public statement confirming his position that the female succession issue did apply to Schleswig and that he resolved to preserve the Helstat.[147] The Holstein estates then protested to the Federal Diet. Response was overwhelming as declarations of support for the duchies poured in from all over Germany defending the German nationality of Schleswig-Holstein. King Christian died in December of 1847 before announcing the introduction of a new constitution that would preserve the state by giving it a facelift. King Frederick, his successor, continued the late King's plans. The Schleswig-Holsteiners wanted a separate constitutional arrangement and entry of Schleswig into the Federal Diet. The Eiderdanes (National Liberals)[148] forced King Frederick to issue a proclamation declaring that Schleswig would become part of the Danish kingdom and that German Holstein would be allowed to go their own way. The Germans in Schleswig and Holstein rebelled by setting up a provisional government for Schleswig-Holstein. They then appealed to the Diet for protection. King Frederick William of Prussia responded to the call for military aide by sending in troops to drive the Danes out of Schleswig.[149] In reacting as harshly and quickly as he had, Frederick William neglected to secure the approval of the other European Powers. The consequence was that England, Russia,

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[147] Ibid., 39.

[148] They were named after the Eider River, which separates Schleswig from Holstein.

[149] Paul M. Kennedy. *The Rise and Fall of the Great Powers: Economic Change and Military Conflict from 1500 to 2000*. (New York: Random House, Inc., 1987). 162.

France and Austria pressured the king to withdraw from Schleswig-Holstein. With Prussia now out of the way the Danes quickly regained control of Schleswig-Holstein and ended what was referred to as the First Slesvig War in 1850. However, the succession issue had not been settled by any of these actions leading to an 1852 meeting in London of the European Powers. As a result, the Treaty of London was signed guaranteeing the territorial integrity of Denmark, and settled the succession to Denmark and both duchies on the Glücksburg branch of the Danish royal house, which derived its claim through the female line. Duke Christian Augustus of Augustenburg, who represented a collateral line, renounced his claim to the duchies and accepted a money indemnity. Denmark in turn guaranteed the inseparability of the duchies and their continued status in personal union with Denmark.[150] The Danish King also promised not to annex Schleswig or change the duchies' legal status without consultation with the European Powers.

In March 1863, Danish King Frederick IV unilaterally imposed new constitutional orders on Schleswig. When he died eight months later without an heir, the Great Powers supported the claim of Prince Christian of Schleswig-Holstein Soenderborg-Glücksburg, who succeeded to the throne while agreeing to carry out the new constitution. According to Bismarck this action was in direct violation of the Treaty of London. Challenging him was the German Duke Christian August of Augustenburg, who had succession rights to the duchies and was widely recognized among the Germans as the Duke of Schleswig-Holstein. What followed was a groundswell of popular opinion engulfing the German states, demanding the separation of the duchies

[150] Carr, 40-41.

from Denmark and their entry into the Germanic Confederation as well as recognition of the duke. The duke won the support of a majority of the German Confederation. Against this majority stood Austria and Prussia, who supported King Christian, providing he adhered to the treaties of 1852.[151] In adopting this position, Bismarck had joined two separate but related issues in a conditional relationship. He kept Austria in play by assuring Austrian Foreign Minister Rechberg that Prussia would follow the London Treaty, but, in order to retain a pretext for intervening in the duchies, he made this assurance conditional upon Denmark keeping her promises to respect the constitutional status quo in the duchies.[152]

In spite of mixed feelings among themselves, the members of the German Confederation finally voted sanctions against Denmark.[153] The Danish king ignored them. Meanwhile Austria and Prussia moved towards a common policy but with very different motives and goals. Rechberg, of Austria, wanted to use the Danish issue to lay the foundations for conservative Austro-Prussian domination of liberal-national forces in the German Confederation. Bismarck, on the other hand, was attracted by the idea of annexing both duchies to Prussia, using them as a tactical pawn while he waited to see what would develop with Austria in foreign policy and in the Prussian Landtag with regard to the domestic political crisis. In both cases he sought to use the forces of popular nationalism against those of popular liberalism.[154] When the Danish King

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[151] Chester Wells Clark. *Franz Joseph and Bismarck; the Diplomacy of Austria before the War of 1866.* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 1934). 23.

[152] Carr, 40-41.

[153] Clark, 23.

[154] Carr, 40-41.

refused to separate Schleswig from their constitution, war erupted with Prussia and Austria on one side and Denmark on the other.[155]

According to the traditions of the Vienna system, this action should have provoked the European Powers to assemble in Congress to restore the balance of power. Yet Europe was in some disarray due to the actions of the French Emperor Napoleon III. Russia was not prepared to antagonize two countries, which had stood aside while it quelled the Polish revolt. Great Britain did not like the fact that Denmark was attacked, but would need a continental ally to intervene, and France, Britain's only feasible partner, inspired little confidence.[156] The result was that in October 1864, through the Treaty of Vienna, the King of Denmark conceded to the King of Prussia and the Emperor of Austria the areas of Holstein, Schleswig and Lauenburg and agreed to recognize the dispositions they made for these territories.[157]

But Bismarck was not happy with just getting Holstein, Schleswig, and Lauenburg from Denmark. What he wanted further was Austria out of the German Confederation. In order to expel Austria from the Confederation, Bismarck deliberately provoked a war between Prussia, allied with Italy, and Austria, seconded by Bavaria, Württemberg, Saxony, Hanover, Baden, and several smaller German states.[158] This was to also be a step toward the unification of Germany under Prussian dominance. Bismarck used the dispute between Prussia and Austria over administration of Schleswig-Holstein as a pretext for precipitating the conflict. The basis of this dispute was Austria's supposedly

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[155] Wawro, 17.

[156] Kissinger, 113.

[157] Carr, 85.

[158] Wawro, 16-17.

failure to follow the Gastein Convention. The Gastein Convention was a treaty signed by both Austria and Prussia dividing up the responsibilities and administration of the duchies. Bismarck purposely made the treaty as suffocating as possible to draw Austria into a war. Austria would administer to Holstein while Prussia would administer to Schleswig. Prussia also got concessions in Holstein, which included the naval base at Kiel, a garrison in Rendsburg, construction of a canal and rights of access to Schleswig. Lauenburg was sold to Prussia outright. The treaty heavily favored Prussia (as Bismarck had hoped) and intentionally set the foundation for future problems. In particular the rights of access were never clarified between troop movements or just civilian traffic. When Austria brought the dispute before the German diet and also decided to convene the Holstein diet, Prussia, declaring that the Gastein Convention[159] had thereby been nullified, invaded Holstein. When the German diet responded by voting for a partial mobilization against Prussia, Bismarck declared that the German Confederation was ended. Due to the ability to mobilize her forces faster than her enemies, Prussia overran the German states allied with Austria and crushed the Austrians at Sadowa (Königgrätz). The treaty that was then arbitrated by Napoleon III gave Schleswig-Holstein, Hanover, Hesse-Kassel, Nassau, and the city of Frankfurt to Prussia. It also allowed the dissolution of the German Confederation and created the Northern German Confederation and a confederation of southern German states.[160] Austria was forced out of the now dissolute German Confederation. All of the losers, except Austria and Bavaria, had to pay an indemnity to Prussia. The kingdoms of

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[159] Otto Pflanze. *Bismarck and the Development of Germany: The Period of Consolidation, 1871-1880.* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1963) 257-258.

[160] Kennedy, 186.

Bavaria, Württemberg, Saxony, and Baden signed treaties with Prussia basically letting Prussia control certain aspects of their government and allowing the Prussian army to fight for them, setting the stage for future annexation and the unification of all the German states. It must be noted that Wilhelm I wanted considerable annexations of Austrian territory, whereas Bismarck intended to offer rather generous terms not taking further territory .[161] The fact that Bismarck insisted upon and was able to get a quick peace without annexation or indemnities from either Austria or Bavaria went a long way in easing the tensions between Austria and Prussia and leaving room for future alliances.[162]

The emergence of Prussia as the leading German power and the increasing unification of the German states were viewed with apprehension by Napoleon III after the Prussian victory in the Austro-Prussian War of 1866.[163] Bismarck, at the same time, deliberately encouraged the growing rift between Prussia and France in order to bring the Southern German states into a national union. He ascertained Russian and Italian neutrality and counted on British neutrality. War preparations were pushed on both sides.

The immediate pretext for war presented itself when the throne of Spain was offered to a prince of the house of Hohenzollern-Sigmaringen, a branch of the ruling house of

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[161] Kann, 276.

[162] James J. Sheehan eds. *Imperial Germany.* (New York: New Viewpoints, 1976) 162.

[163] Napoleon III had hoped that Prussia and Austria would wear each other down enough for France to step in. With Prussia's quick victory, Napoleon III was not able to make the territorial gains he had hoped to make, especially in the areas of southern Germany. The southern principalities were wary of both Prussia on one side and France on the other. However, if given a choice they were German in nature and still feared the France of Napoleon I. Also Napoleon III now had an emerging European power on his doorstep, something that made him extremely nervous. Otto Pflanze. *Bismarck and the Development of Germany: The Period of Unification 1815-1871.* Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1963. 291-292.

Prussia in July of 1870. The offer, at first accepted on Bismarck's advice, was rejected (July 12) after strong French protest. But the aggressive French foreign minister, the Duke of Gramont, insisted on further Prussian assurances, which King William I of Prussia refused. He then made remarks to the French parliament that seemed to advocate war with Prussia over the candidacy. To further their cause, Gramont and Napoleon III were determined to humiliate Prussia over the candidacy issue instead of just accepting that they blocked a Prussian prince from the Spanish throne. Gramont was particularly aggressive in stirring up French emotions by leaking information to the French press. Bismarck took full advantage of this by publishing the famous Ems Dispatch [164], which inflamed French feeling even more than they already were, and on July 19, France declared war.

However, this action led to the defeat of Napoleon III at Sedan and then the French forces themselves. The result was that France agreed to pay an indemnity of $1 billion within three years—an indemnity fully paid before the term expired. Also the territory of Alsace – Lorraine was ceded to Germany. Bismarck was adamantly opposed to this action, as it would give the French something to rally around in the future.

Besides establishing the Third French Republic and the German Empire, the Franco-Prussian War had other far-reaching effects. Prussian militarism had triumphed and

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[164] Gramont sent his ambassador Benedetti to Bad Ems to see Wilhelm I to extract certain demands, guarantees and assurances from the King concerning future Hohenzollern candidacies. The dispatch that was sent to Bismarck told of all these. It also explained the Kings reaction and why he reacted the way he did. The last line of the dispatch instructed Bismarck to publish the contents of the telegram. Bismarck says in his memoirs that he then proceeded to mark out certain sentences, words or phrases so that the end product was a dispatch that sounded extremely aggressive and insulting, he very adamantly states that he never added or moved any words in the original dispatch. When published this dispatch roused already tense feelings in both the French and the German people. Lawrence D. Steefel. *Bismarck, the Hohenzollern Candidacy, and the Origins of the Franco-German War of 1870.* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press) Pp. 156-157, 185-189. Also, Prince Otto von Bismarck, *Bismarck: The Man and the Statesman, Voll. II.* ed. Horst Kohl, trans. A.J. Butler. (London: Harper and Brothers Publishers, 1898). 99-101.

laid the groundwork for German imperialistic ventures. The Papal States, no longer protected by Napoleon III, were annexed by Italy, which thus completed its unification. And desire for revenge guided French policy for the following half-century.

No account of the war of 1870-71 would be complete without some reference to the last stage in the creation of Germany. In July 1870 the wave of anti-French feeling, which swept through the cities and towns of South Germany, forced the governments to order mobilization, whether they wanted to or not. South German troops played their part in the campaign with as much enthusiasm as the North Germans. After Sedan it was clear to the southern states that they would have to come to terms with the new political situation. Southern states Baden and Hesse-Darmstadt were ready to join the new Reich, the former with enthusiasm, the latter reluctantly but well aware that with one province already in the North German Confederation she had little option. Predictably Württemberg and Bavaria were much less eager to join. Instead they hoped to create a southern confederation only loosely associated with North Germany. To schemes of this sort Bismarck was adamantly opposed and through the employment of his usual tactics of intrigue, pressure, and blandishments, he forced them in the end to abandon such ideas. By the end of November after difficult negotiations, all four states had signed treaties of accession to the new state.[165]

Bismarck was obliged to make a number of concessions to the southern states. The authority of the federal council was extended in formal matters; for example, its consent was now required for declarations of war. Bavaria and Württemberg were allowed to keep their own railway network and postal and telegraph systems. And while the

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[165] Carr, 206-207.

Württemberg armed forces became part of the Prussian army, the king retained the right to appoint the commander and all officers. Bavaria did even better; her king remained in complete control of the Bavarian army, which would pass under Prussian command only in wartime. In addition she kept her diplomatic corps; and she was to preside over a special foreign affairs committee of the federal council on which Württemberg and Saxony had permanent seats. Although these concessions limited Prussian power they did not seriously weaken it and were a useful foil against the Reichstag whose power Bismarck was determined not to extend.[166]

Assessing how Germany became the power she was before World War I, we see at least two distinctive sets of plans. The first is Bismarck's plan to unite all the German principalities under the Prussian monarchy. He did this deftly and without equal and is also able to maintain the balance of power in Europe. The second was to forge alliances and relationship in all directions, so that Germany would be closer to each of the contending parties than they were to each other.[167] However, Bismarck did not adhere to a strict by-the-book plan, but with variances, which provided for alternative courses of political action. These courses were twofold in character: sometimes they consisted of alternative solutions to a particular political problem; often they were alternative possibilities of alliance with opposed political forces.[168]

The unification of a Prussian-led Germany, devoid of Austrian influence was the ultimate goal for which Bismarck ascribed. That he had a very flexible plan is evident in the way he used issues and conflicts to achieve his ultimate goal. When looking at the

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[166] Carr, 207.

[167] Kissinger, 122.

[168] Sheehan, 164.

timeframe from 1864 to 1871 an amazing diplomatic effort can be seen. One misstep and all of Europe could have erupted into war. However, Bismarck was able to sidestep these landmines and bring together a small group of principalities that would one-day challenge the world. The challenge, after unification, was how could Bismarck keep Germany together?

Anyone who has ever looked into the glazed eyes of a soldier dying on a battlefield will think hard before starting a war

The secret of politics? Make a good treaty with Russia.

Prince Otto von Bismarck-Schonhausen

Chapter IV

Treaties, Alliances and Conventions; Maintaining the Balance of Power

On January 8th 1918, President Woodrow Wilson delivered a speech to the Joint session of Congress outlining his 14 Points. In it he pointed out that:

> *It will be our wish and purpose that the processes of peace, when they are begun, shall be absolutely open and that they shall involve and permit henceforth no secret understandings of any kind. The day of conquest and aggrandizement is gone by; so is also the day of secret covenants entered into in the interest of particular governments and likely at some unlooked-for moment to upset the peace of the world. It is this happy fact, now clear to the view of every public man whose thoughts do not still linger in an age that is dead and gone, which makes it possible for every nation whose purposes are consistent with justice and the peace of the world to avow nor or at any other time the objects it has in view.*

Wilson recognized that the secret alliances made since 1860 on, were a major cause of World War I. Further, he saw the need for a League of Nations to prevent future wars.[169] What Wilson and others realized was that while the Congress of Vienna had set boundaries and guidelines that had lasted almost a hundred years, it had also been a shaky hundred years. The five main powers (England, France, Russia, Germany and Austria-Hungary) each had their own agendas, which they used to manipulate the system. It is these manipulations in the form of alliances and hidden treaties that systematically eroded the gains of the Congress. One of the chief architects of these alliances was Germany's chancellor Otto von Bismarck. Bismarck knew that his fledgling nation needed to protect itself so he began to ally Germany with her neighbors. The problem was that none of Germany's neighbors cared for the other. Italy and Austria were at odds over northeastern Italy, Austria and Russia disagreed over the

[169] Louis Auchincloss. *Woodrow Wilson.* (New York: Penguin Putnam Inc., 2000). 92

Balkans, France and Italy had little reason to trust each other. And everyone still kept an eye on France because of its volatile and aggressive past. Consequently, Bismarck decided to bind the other European powers to Germany with secret alliances and treaties in order to maintain the status quo. It is these intertwining alliances and their complexity that is of interest.

Now that Bismarck's plan on the unification of Germany had come to fruition, the chancellor turned his attention to keeping other countries from appropriating regions of Germany and also to place Germany in what he believed to be her rightful place among the European powers. Bismarck had weakened the position of Austria and France as well as enhanced that of Prussia, while he had deliberately avoided wrecking the political system under which Europe was ruled by the five major powers. The continuity of the international order of Europe was a conscious aim of Bismarckian diplomacy since it would contribute to the security of Germany.[170] Bismarck also knew that he had to be wary of France because of the loss of Alsace-Lorraine during the Franco Prussian War. However, it was clear that France had no chance of revenge unless she found allies.[171] Bismarck favored the present Republican government of France because he felt that this government would have fewer opportunities of finding allies in Austria-Hungary and Russia.[172] The most appropriate way to keep France from gaining allies was for Germany to win friends and allies of its own. This setting allowed Bismarck to weave his intertwining alliances.

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[170] Holborn, 236.

[171] George F. Kennan. *The Decline of Bismarck's European Order: Franco-Russian Relations, 1875-1890.* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1979). 7.

[172] Most of the countries of the time were still monarchies. The French government had changed in the wake of the Franco-Prussian war from an Empire to a democratically elected Republic.

To gain a better understanding of how Bismarck protected Germany while further isolating France, one must look at all the alliances and treaties made and how they entwine and entangle with each other creating a conflicting web that basically pits one country against another with Germany sheltered and France the likely focus of any war. Bismarck basically accomplished this in three phases.[173] In the first phase, from 1871 to 1878, he sought to consolidate Germany's new dominance within Europe by maintaining the isolation of France and fostering the traditional ties between Germany, Austria-Hungary and Russia based on the Holy Alliance. During the second phase of his diplomacy as Chancellor, between 1879 and 1885, Bismarck had to abandon the *laissez-faire* approach, which he had adopted in the early years of his Chancellorship. The primary reason was that by the late 1870s the Ottoman Empire in Europe began to disintegrate, creating a period of confrontations between Russia and Austria for supremacy in the Balkans.[174] In order to address this new instability, Bismarck promoted the development of a more formal system of alliances with Austria in 1879, with Russia and Austria in 1881, with Italy and Austria in 1882, and with Romania and Austria in 1883. Bismarck even sought to improve relations with France towards the end of this phase, by German support of French expansion in Africa. This might have helped France to come to terms with the loss of Alsace-Lorraine.[175] However, despite all this diplomatic activity, in the third and final phase, between 1885 and his dismissal in 1890, the intricate system of alliances, began to show signs of strain. A protracted

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[173] Matthew S. Seligmann. *Germany from Reich to Republic, 1871-1918: Politics, Hierarchy and Elites.* (New York: St. Martin's Press, 2000). 41.

[174] Ibid.

[175] Ibid.

crisis over the future of Bulgaria damaged relations between Russia and Austria beyond repair, and this, coupled with a renewed spirit of *revanche* in France, opened up the possibility of a Franco-Russian alliance. Bismarck's response was to maintain Germany's alliance with Austria, but also to enter into a separate agreement with Russia, through the Reinsurance Treaty, in 1887.[176] These phases and their implications are detailed further below through a closer look at eight of the major alliances and treaties that pertained to Germany and how they interacted with the rest of Europe.

Directly after the unification of Germany, in 1872, a meeting took place between the three emperors: Kaiser Wilhelm I, Franz Joseph, and Alexander II in Schönbrunn, Germany to show monarchial solidarity. The result was a loose alliance known as the Three Emperors Agreement. Although, for Bismarck, the old Holy Roman Empire was defunct, at this point he willingly collaborated in the resuscitation of monarchical solidarity in order to block France from either a two-front entente with Russia or a Catholic league with Austria.[177] Basically the result was an alliance against revolution in all its forms.[178] The agreement was to also preserve the social order of the conservative powers of Europe and to keep the peace between Austria-Hungary and Russia.[179] Bismarck was very busy while this alliance was being worked through keeping down British fears that the balance of power would not be upset. Although wary of this diplomatic action, the British accepted the resulting improved relations of

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[176] Ibid.

[177] Allen Mitchell, *Bismarck and the French Nation, 1848-1890.* (New York: Pegasus,1971), 83.

[178] William L. Langer, *European Alliances and Alignments: 1871-1890*. (New York: Knopf,1931), 25.

[179] Holborn, 237.

the three nations but did not reply when ask if they wanted to join. Italy; however, fearing support of the European monarchies[180] with the Papacy if they did not accept, joined by the end of 1873. Other political action on behalf of Germany saw General Helmut von Moltke, head of the German General Staff, persuade Russia to agree on a military convention between their two countries in 1873.[181] This agreement required 200,000 Russian or German troops to be supplied to whichever country was being attacked by a third power. The Austrians and the Russians also signed an agreement, which provided for mutual consultation, the renunciation of new alliances, and the common conduct of policy should aggression by a third power occur. Although the meeting of the three emperors was the first of its kind in a long time, none of the parties involved really had any intention of supporting each other, as they had seemed to agree. The Russians were not willing to go to war with Germany against France should France attack Germany and Germany was not willing to go to war against Austria-Hungary should they attack Russia.[182] Bismarck knew this; however, he also knew that if the other powers didn't know this they would hesitate before making any moves towards Germany. Thus creating a window of time, giving Germany time to regroup and gain support elsewhere.

Looking at the events that lead up to the Congress of Berlin a pattern emerged indicating what would develop as the underlying problem in Europe at the time, what to

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[180] Most notable of the monarchies that Italy was worried about were the Austrians because of their Catholic connections with the papacy.

[181] Bismarck was wary of this convention; however, he supported it because of the thought of military support against France.

[182] Taylor, *The Struggle for the Mastery in Europe: 1848-1918*, 218-220.

do with the dying Ottoman Empire.[183] England wanted basically to prop the old empire up so that the Russians would not have control of the either the Dardanelles or Bosporus straits as well as keep the path to the Suez Canal open at all times. At this time the Russians were making every effort to frustrate British attempts to secure control of the Suez Canal.[184] The English believed that any major power in close proximity to the canal could effectively seal off the canal and prevent protection of their interests in India. The Russians had disliked the Turks for centuries and wanted them out of Europe and the Orthodox cross put back upon Hagia Sophia's cathedral. They also wanted territories in the Balkans and the formation of small autonomous states in Romania, Serbia, Montenegro and Bulgaria along with free access through the straits. Austria-Hungary had interest in Bosnia-Herzegovina; and did not want it or other emerging countries owing allegiance to Russia. In particular she did not want a large Bulgarian government controlling ethnic Romanians or Hungarians. Although France did not really have an interest in the Near East she wanted to get back into favor in the world of European politics. Similarly, Italy had interest in Tunis, but really had no concern when it came to Turkey. Bismarck on the other hand wished for issues concerning Turkey to go away. To him the Ottoman Empire was causing more problems in Europe than they were worth. Preserving the peace in Europe at the expense of Turkey was a justifiable cause for Bismarck.[185] Thus, when the Russians could not come to an agreement with the Austrians and the British after the Russian

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[183] Volker R. Berghahn. *Imperial Germany 1871-1914: Economy, Society, Culture and Politics*. (Providence: Berghahn Books, 1994). 264.

[184] Langer, *Alliances and Alignments*, 40.

[185] Ibid., 24.

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defeat of the Turks in the Russo-Turkish war, a congress was called in order to iron out all the issues and bring a peaceful settlement among all countries involved. The congress, which convened at Berlin on June 13, 1878, was considered to be one of the most brilliant political assemblies of the time, not unworthy of comparison with the congresses of Vienna and Paris. Most of the leading statesmen were present, though for a time it seemed as though Disraeli (British Prime Minister) and Gorchakov (Russian foreign minister and chancellor) would be prevented from attending due to bad health. Bismarck had also been suffering from illness for a long time, but he came to Berlin full of determination and energy.[186] Bismarck chaired the Congress as an "honest broker". Throughout the course of the transactions he left no doubt as to who was the dominating figure and influence. The members of the congress were agreed that without him the meeting might well have ended in failure. During the various sessions he was rigorous in his insistence that irrelevant discussions be dispensed with and that an agreement on disputed points be reached with greatest dispatch.[187] Outside the formal sessions he was intensely active in furthering the negotiations between parties concerned, and in pressing on for a compromise when the situation became critical. His complete impartiality cannot be better illustrated than that each side accused him afterwards of favoring the other.[188] Regardless of the congress, most of the agreements had been made before the congress began and were of a vague nature. The main intent of all powers represented was to get what they could out of the

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[186] Ibid., 150.

[187] Ibid

[188] Ibid.

congress.[189] Nonetheless, by the end of the Congress, Russia had lost most of her military gains while Austria-Hungary had gained the territory of Bosnia-Herzegovina without expending any effort at all. Romania, Serbia and Montenegro received their independence and Bessarabia became part of Russia.[190] For Russia, the Congress of Berlin was humiliating and disastrous. To the Russians it appeared that they had fought a great and difficult war in order to secure advantages for Austria and England with little for themselves. They had not even obtained the opening of the straits as they had hoped. For Bismarck the final settlement was a mixed blessing. To be sure, he had the satisfaction of seeing policy he had advocated so long finally secure general acceptance. He had, from the very start, made his position extremely clear. The Balkans and Turkey were simply not worth a deluge of blood in Europe. The preservation of peace among the great powers was the primary consideration and could best be obtained by a policy of reciprocal compensation for all concerned. Not so attractive to Bismarck, at the end of this Near Eastern crisis was the collapse of the Three Emperor's League, his cherished "triangular rampart." Worse yet, the Near Eastern Crisis had forced the German government into a position of resistance to Russian hopes and expectations and had thereby cast a shadow over Russian-German relations. Conversely, it opens up the prospect of relationships with England and Austria-Hungary as an alternative to the Eastern orientation. Final judgment of the Congress of Berlin might state that while not perfect, it was framed to meet a particular

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[189] Ibid., 153.

[190] Ibid., 161.

and very dangerous situation and was designed to keep the peace between the great powers.[191]

Due to the Russian anger over the outcome of the Congress and their dissolution of the Three Emperor's League, Bismarck, in fear of retaliation, then formed the Dual Alliance between Germany and Austria-Hungary in 1879.[192] Thus began the longest lasting of all the alliances conceived in Bismarck's time. It was essentially an alliance where each partner agreed to protect the other in case of attack by any of the other powers. Fear of Russian retaliation over the Congress of Berlin was not the only reason Bismarck formed this new alliance. Austria-Hungary's structural, historical and ideological affinities with Germany were exploited when convincing Emperor Wilhelm I of the need for the Dual Alliance.[193] Bismarck also felt that Germany could control Austria-Hungary and keep her from starting any war without Germany's approval.[194] He believed that Germany could restrain Austrian policy in the Balkans preventing Germany from being drawn into a war with Russia over southeast Europe. Thus this alliance brought an element of stability in Europe since it would both concern Russia sufficiently to want better relations with Germany and to also provide Germany with the power to control Austrian policy towards her Slav neighbors.[195]

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[191] Ibid., 163-165.

[192] Geiss, 35.

[193] Ibid.

[194] William Norton Medlicott. *The Congress of Berlin and After: A Diplomatic History of the Near Eastern Settlement, 1878-1880.* (Hamden: Archon Books, 1963). 58.

[195] James Joll. *The Origins of the First World War.* 2nd ed. (Hampshire: Ashford Colour Press Ltd., 1992). 46.

However, Bismarck had no intention of binding himself exclusively to Austria-Hungary, since he knew that France still needed allies and a partnership with an angry Russia could be of value. He therefore quickly worked towards repairing the broken links with Russia. Bismarck's chief goal was to obtain Russian neutrality in the event of a German war with France and a settlement of the Near East question.[196] In 1881 an agreement was signed by Russia, Austria-Hungary and Germany known as the Three Emperors League. The agreement pledged benevolent neutrality if one power was at war with a fourth power.[197] It also contained the coordination of their policies with regard to Turkey and the Balkans.[198]

In February 1882 a Russian emissary visited Paris. This action fueled the German concern that Russia might be planning an alliance with France. Bismarck responded by working on a defensive alliance with Italy.[199] The result was that the Italians were brought into the Dual Alliance of Germany and Austria-Hungary in 1882, changing it into the Triple Alliance. This alliance, of course, was aimed directly at France. If France attacked any of the three countries without direct provocation, the others would join in defense. The alliance would also place Austria-Hungary in a geographical position protecting Germany from a two front attack in case both France and Russia attacked

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[196] Eric Brandenburg. *From Bismarck to the World War; a History of German Foreign Policy 1870-1914*. trans. Annie Elizabeth Adams. (London: Oxford University Press, 1933). 12-13.

[197] Joseph Vincent Fuller. *Bismarck's Diplomacy at its Zenith.* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 1922). 9.

[198] Lynn Abrams. *Bismarck and the German Empire, 1871-1918*. (London: Routledge, 1995). 37.

[199] William Simpson. *The Second Reich: Germany, 1871-1918.* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1995). 58-59.

simultaneously.[200] They would also aid each other in any war with two or more of the great powers.[201]

Serbia signed an alliance with Austria-Hungary, in 1881, to basically protect Serbia from Russian aggression. Bismarck once again saw an opportunity to play off of Austria-Hungary's fears and pushed for Austria-Hungary to make this alliance. In 1883 Germany acceded to a friendship and alliance treaty of Austria-Hungary and Rumania. This treaty committed the two great powers to come to the assistance of Rumania if she were attacked by Russia and vice versa.

Besides France, England was the only other of the major powers that had not been ensnared in one of Bismarck's alliances.[202] In February 1887, Bismarck arranged the First Mediterranean Agreement, the main goal of which was to enlist the support of England on behalf of Austria. However, this was not to happen unless Germany promised support for Italy, which Bismarck had already done with the Triple Alliance.[203] The First Mediterranean Agreement was an understanding among Britain, Italy, and Austria to maintain the status quo in the Mediterranean, Adriatic, Aegean, and Black Sea areas.[204] That action clearly caused a barrier to French and Russian expansion without incurring Russian hostility. This agreement also helped reassure Italy in the case of French aggression in the Mediterranean.

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[200] Eber Malcolm Carroll. *Germany and the Great Powers, 1866-1914; a Study in Public Opinion and Foreign Policy.* (New York: Prentice Hall, Inc., 1938). 168-169.

[201] Holborn, 243.

[202] Ibid.

[203] Langer, *Alliances and Alignments*, 397.

[204] Paul M. Kennedy. *The Rise of Anglo-German Antagonism: 1860-1914*. (Atlantic Highlands: The Ashfield Press, 1987). 185-192.

Having an alliance already in place with Austria and Italy, Bismarck needed to find a way to bind Russia to Germany without alienating Austria-Hungary. The ensuing Reinsurance Treaty of 1887 between Russia and Germany provided that either power would remain neutral if the other was attacked by a third power. It did not apply if one of them attacked France or Austria. Thus Russia would be neutral if France attacked Germany and Germany in turn, would be neutral if Austria or Britain attacked Russia. In this respect the Reinsurance Treaty, which was to last for only three years, was compatible with the Dual Alliance of 1879.[205] There were other important provisions in the treaty: Germany recognized Russian rights in Bulgaria and Russia's right to take Constantinople at anytime. This was certainly counter to Austrian and British interest in the area, but a safe bet for Bismarck because the First Mediterranean Agreement would keep Russia from acting on it. This treaty was kept secret because popular opinion in both Austria-Hungary and Russia would have been against it.[206]

In December 1887 with problems in Bulgaria escalating, Bismarck pushed for a Second Mediterranean Agreement. This came about because Ferdinand of Saxe-Coburg was elected prince of Bulgaria. The trouble was that the new prince was an officer in the Austro-Hungarian army. Russia got excited because of the possibility of an Austrian ally on the Russian border and asked Bismarck for help, which he refused. At this point the German General staff suggested a preventive war to get Russia out of the Balkans once and for all. Nonetheless, Bismarck only stopped the granting of loans to Russia, which put a brake on Russia and eventually forced her to go to Paris for

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[205] Michael Sturmer. *The German Empire, 1870-1918.* (New York: Modern Library, 2000). 36.

[206] Simpson, 59.

loans. Bismarck felt that the British, being the superior naval force of the time, should be more proactive in protecting their interest in the Mediterranean.[207] The Second Mediterranean Agreement merely stipulated that an understanding would be reached on measures to respect the integrity of the Ottoman Empire.

If you were to lay all the alliances out on a table and look at how each one joined with the others you can see just how intertwining they were. Bismarck had planned that he could play each power off on the others by using these countless alliances, each intertwined with others, to keep Germany relatively safe. As long as Bismarck held his influential position within Germany "his" alliance system seemed to work. A major difficulty was that almost all of the provisions of these alliances were secret, even within Germany and only Bismarck understood them fully. Thus Bismarck's removal, either by political or health reasons, would be potentially disastrous.

The path to World War I is laid out with much intrigue and diplomatic maneuvering. The most prominent and central figure in all of these alliances was Bismarck. But did he purposely maneuver Germany into war with the rest of Europe? It seems unlikely that such was his intent. What Bismarck had planned to do was to protect Germany from the other powers, mainly France. He used the alliances as a means to carry out this goal. Unfortunately Wilhelm II was too militaristic and neither he nor the successive Chancellors after Bismarck understood what Bismarck had done or how to maintain the system. Further the secret alliances and treaties, when made public, caused distrust all over Europe; primarily aimed at Germany. Thus the war that Bismarck had worked hard to prevent began in Europe in the summer of 1914.

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[207] Kennedy, *Anglo-German Antagonism*, 185-192.

If there is ever another war in Europe, it will come out of some damned silly thing in the Balkans.

Prince Otto von Bismarck-Schonhausen

Chapter V

The Path to War: The Fall of Bismarck and the Rise of the German Military Machine

On 28 June 1914, a Serbian extremist assassinated Archduke Franz Ferdinand, heir to the Hapsburg throne, throwing all of Europe into chaos and escalating a series of already tense events that would eventually be the start of World War I. These events, which culminated from a mixture of failed foreign policies, decaying dynasties, nationalism and revenge, had their humble beginnings roughly a hundred years earlier in the very Congress that was assembled to prevent next big war. The Congress of Vienna was convened in 1815 by the major European powers[208] to control the makeup of Europe so that they each could maintain their power, prestige, and to prevent another major war that would decimate Europe as the Napoleonic wars had done before. These powers established a system that would pit the combined might of all the other countries against any aggressor, thus maintaining the balance of power in Europe. This system allowed a balance of power that maintained a relative peace in Europe until the outbreak of World War I in 1914. Although the balance of power allowed relative peace, it was not able to prevent the many changes permeating Europe at the time. A series of revolutions began to threaten the peace of Europe in 1820, 1830 and again in 1848. This was the first challenge for the balance of power concept that was established at Vienna. The second challenge was the many smaller wars that were fought from 1850 onwards. These wars did not destroy this system, but they did put a tremendous strain on it and ultimately changed the face of Europe.

[208] England, Russia, Austria, France and Prussia.

The most profound change from 1815 to 1890 was found in Prussia. Prussia actually ceased to exist in 1871 being incorporated into the newly formed German Empire. However, the Prussian monarchy still controlled the destiny of the fledgling nation. Though Wilhelm I was the King, Chancellor Otto von Bismarck had orchestrated Prussia's rise to prominence. More importantly was how Bismarck had actually planned the rise of a united Germany under Prussian rule. Bismarck never really had a formally written plan. Nonetheless, he knew what he wanted to do, where he wanted to go and how he wanted to get there. What he needed were events to occur that could give him reason to take action. Bismarck did not want Prussia to look like the aggressor so that he could obtain what he wanted without pitting the other powers against Prussia. In order for him to start unifying the German states under Prussian rule, Bismarck needed to get Austria out of the German Confederation. He used the Schleswig-Holstein problem and two short wars between Prussia and the Dutch and Austrians to do just that. Once Austria was out of the German Confederation, Bismarck then used the Prussian people's fear of the creation of another Napoleonic France to manipulate a short war with France, which pushed the remaining German principalities into an alliance with Prussia. This alliance would lead them to becoming a part of the German nation in 1871. Once the German states were unified under Prussian rule, Bismarck knew that unified Prussia needed to be protected from the other powers until it was strong enough to defend itself. As discussed earlier, Bismarck then created alliances so entangling that every major power was checked by the other powers keeping the focus of any war off of Germany.

However, Bismarck did not plan for everything. Kaiser Wilhelm I had been ruling Prussia and the resulting German Empire for over thirty years. Bismarck had also been in power for nearly 30 years during which he made many political enemies in and outside of Germany. Meanwhile, Europe had also changed since the Congress of Vienna. Increasingly, European countries were securing resources or prestige due to colonization. With the boom of the industrial revolution, underdeveloped areas like Asia, Southeast Asia, the Caribbean, Africa and islands throughout the Pacific were ripe for modern European settlements. Another change going on in Europe was occurring in the Ottoman Empire. The empire was slowly dying causing much chaos across Europe due to the importance of the Bosporus Straits and the Balkans. With all of this as a backdrop, the problem in the Balkans would be a central theme throughout European politics in the 19th century, as it remains a problem today.

With the death of Wilhelm I in March of 1888, his son Frederick III then became the new Kaiser of Germany; however, he was terminally ill with throat cancer and died three months afterwards. His son Wilhelm II then became the next and last emperor of Germany. Wilhelm II as Emperor brought on a dramatic shift in German foreign policy. He was more militaristic and relied more on his General Staff then he did on his diplomats. While Bismarck did not see war with Russia as inevitable, some of the General Staff did and they had the ear of the Kaiser. Thus, Bismarck found that he could not manipulate the new Kaiser as easily as the old one. The resulting clashes over foreign policy and relationships with other countries came to a head in 1890 and the Kaiser demanded Bismarck's retirement. The forced retirement of Bismarck on 20

March 1890 marked the end of one era and the beginning of a new and more aggressive era. Gone were the times when diplomacy ruled the day.

Wilhelm II chose Leo von Caprivi as Bismarck's successor. Caprivi was a career general who had worked the post of chief of admiralty for several years.[209] It is in this post that he had the occasion to work with both the Reichstag and the Kaiser and he established himself as the next logical choice to succeed Bismarck. Caprivi was also a Prussian aristocrat and a career soldier.[210] He did not nor had he ever owned a landed estate. He was proud to have made his way by his own merit and self-sufficiency without inherited wealth.[211] Because of these accomplishments and because Caprivi had been driven throughout his career by a wish to advance the welfare of the nation, he expected others to be capable of comparable deeds.[212] Therefore, Caprivi differed greatly from Bismarck. Caprivi believed in co-operation and friendship not in coercion and political maneuverings. He intended to adopt a neutral position when it came to party politics and appeal, not to self-interest, but to the patriotism of the country's politicians.[213] Where Bismarck would bully and intimidate to get his way, Caprivi would try to compromise and settle issues to everyone's satisfaction. Eventually Caprivi realized that he had miscalculated his approach and that no genuine consensus of

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[209] Charlotte Sempell, "Constitutional and Political Problems of the Second Chancellor, Leo von Caprivi," *Journal of Modern History.* 25:3 (September 1953): 237-238.

[210] Seligmann, 71.

[211] Ibid., 77.

[212] Ibid.

[213] Ibid., 77-78.

opinion could be arrived at in German matters.[214] His non-partisan style of government was fundamentally incapable of securing a loyal parliamentary following and it was because of this failure that his tenure as Chancellor would only last four years.[215]

Once he took office Caprivi soon let the Reinsurance Treaty with Russia lapse. Friedrich von Holstein, the influential Foreign Office official and Bismarck hater, persuaded him that the secret treaty contradicted Germany's commitment to Austria and would become highly embarrassing to Berlin if ever disclosed by Russia.[216] Holstein claimed that the treaty favored Russia and that Germany should count on Britain not Russia to come to Germany's aid in the event of an attack.[217] For Holstein, the treaty gave Germany no advantages to compensate for grave danger of alienating allies like Austria, Italy and Rumania. It did not guarantee Germany against a French attack nor did it eliminate the possibility of a Franco-Russian alliance.[218] Caprivi further distanced Germany from Russia by signing a treaty with Britain over Zanzibar and Heligoland.[219] This treaty, known as the Heligoland-Zanzibar Treaty, tightened Britain's control of the Nile River and East Mediterranean Sea while limiting German interest in east Africa. Germany, gained the strategic island of Heligoland in the North Sea, while

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[214] John C. Rohl. *Germany without Bismarck; the Crisis of Government in the Second Reich, 1890-1900.* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1967). 9-10.

[215] Seligmann, 79.

[216] Otto Pflanze. *Bismarck and the Development of Germany: The Period of Fortification 1880-1898.* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1963). 387.

[217] Steven Ozment. *A Mighty Fortress: A New History of the German People.* (New York: Harper Collins Publishers, 2004). 234.

[218] Norman Rich. *Friedrich von Holstein, Politics, and Diplomacy in the Era of Bismarck and Wilhelm II, Vol. I*. (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1965). 312.

[219] Taylor, *The Struggle*, 329.

Britain further solidified her protection of the Eastern Mediterranean. Caprivi also assumed that because of this treaty, Germany now had an important ally in England.[220] However, this treaty did something Bismarck had worked hard to prevent, push Russia towards an alliance with France. Within five years of the lapse of the Reinsurance Treaty, France and Russia were partners in trade and two years after that negotiated a defensive alliance against Germany.[221]

The lapse of the Reinsurance treaty wasn't the only thing Caprivi did in his short term. After one of many disagreements with the Kaiser, the two offices of Chancellor and minister-president were separated. This was only the second time it had happened in the history of the Reich.[222] Count Botho Eulenberg, a strict conservative, was appointed minister-president. For Caprivi this move was advantageous because the Chancellor now would not have to be involved in every Prussian crisis, while at the same time the move would constantly pit Caprivi against the conservatives who were beginning to turn against him.[223] In fact, it was Caprivi's continuing conflict between the minister-president Count Botho Eulenberg and the conservatives that prompted the Kaiser to demand both the Chancellor's and the minister-president's resignation in October of 1894.[224] It is something of an irony that one of the most enduring legacies of Caprivi's time in office was not the much hoped for cleansing from German politics of all the rancor and bitterness that had marked the Bismarckian years, but rather the

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[220] Ibid.

[221] Ozmet, 234.

[222] Sempell, 244.

[223] Ibid.

[224] Ibid., 252-254.

establishment of a whole new breed of organized opposition so vehement in its dissent that it was willing to employ any means, no matter how unscrupulous, to achieve its ends.[225]

Caprivi's main predicament was twofold; first since Bismarck's dismissal; the royal entourage had begun to grow in power and influence. Feeling that the Kaiser was too unstable to handle public criticism, the entourage went out of their way to "handle" him.[226] Caprivi refused to be bullied by the entourage or guided by the Kaiser's eccentricities. He also refused to shelter the Kaiser from the outside world and it was Caprivi's neglect of these aspects of government that contributed to his fall from power.[227]

Secondly Caprivi did not understand that the Kaiser Wilhelm II did not want to just rule the country; he wanted to run it also. For Wilhelm II, Germany was nothing but a giant toy created by the Almighty to please him (Wilhelm II).[228] Wilhelm had been annoyed at Caprivi's insistence that he (Caprivi) was a representative of the responsible government rather than a pliable instrument of the crown.[229] To accomplish his ends, in an image to suite him, Wilhelm II needed Chancellors who were weak leaders so that he could bask in all the prestige and glory of *Weltpolitik.*[230] His appointments of Prince Clodwig von Hohenlohe-Schillingsfürst (1894-1900), Prince Bernhard von Bülow (1900-

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[225] Seligmann. 81.

[226] Berghan. 241-242.

[227] Ibid., 242.

[228] Sturmer, 85.

[229] Ibid., 91.

[230] Ibid.

1909) and Theobald von Bethman Hollweg (1909-1917) were the steps in this direction. Hohenlohe was 80 years old when he was appointed Chancellor. He was tired and not ready for the demands that the office of Chancellor were about to put upon him. Where Caprivi was notorious for his obstinacy and sense of loyalty towards his colleagues, Hohenlohe simply refused to act.[231] He did not want to quarrel with the Kaiser and sought to keep out of disputes in the Ministry of State.[232] The Kaiser took advantage of Hohenlohe's weakness by appointing men of his choosing to the Ministry and by intervening in home and foreign affairs.[233] Hohenlohe retired in 1900.[234] Regardless of this weak approach, there were a few major items to note during Hohenlohe's tenure as Chancellor. For one thing it was the Hohenlohe government that struck a compromise between the agrarian and industrial factions that had been bickering since Caprivi had come into office.[235] It was also during Hohenlohe's term that Admiral Alfred von Tirpitz was selected as Secretary of the State for the Navy and that the Pan Slavic League and the Navy League began to assert themselves in politics. Both leagues supported Tirpitz and his idea that Germany needed to rapidly build up a navy both as a deterrent and in order to compete with the other naval powers, most notable of these being Great Britain.[236] It was these pressure groups that whipped up popular support with the people over colonization, not because they wanted more colonies but because they

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[231] Rohl., 118-119.

[232] Ibid.

[233] Ibid.

[234] Mary Fulbrook. *A Concise History of Germany. 2nd ed*. (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2004) 142.

[235] Ibid.

[236] Ibid.

wanted a bigger Navy. It is interesting to note that the Navy League was getting its financial backing from industries such as Krupp and Stumm (major producers of steel and iron).[237]

Prince Bernhard von Bülow became Chancellor in October 1900 and remained in office until July 1909. He became the longest serving of Wilhelm's Chancellors.[238] He was also the only one chosen with much prior thought and deliberation and as executor of a clearly defined political strategy.[239] These made von Bülow's position as Chancellor initially a strong one.[240] He was the first Chancellor that the Kaiser trusted absolutely. Von Bülow regarded himself as the Kaiser's 'political chief of staff', who would institute personal rule in the good sense.[241] Regardless of this positive setting, von Bülow had made a critical error. His standing with the executive, his ability to shape the course of policy, his influence over appointments and ultimately his political survival, all rested upon his skill in preserving the Kaiser's trust.[242] Thus, he had become a prisoner of the political system, which he had helped to create. By reducing his office from that of the head of the responsible government to that of a servile courtier, von Bülow had created a situation where his entire political system depended on his ability to maintain the Kaiser's support. When the Kaiser began to withdraw his

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[237] Ibid.

[238] Seligmann, 94.

[239] Ibid.

[240] Ibid., 95.

[241] Ibid.

[242] Ibid., 95-96.

trust the Chancellor von Bülow's political system entered a period of protracted crisis resulting in his dismissal in 1909.[243]

Theobald von Bethmann Hollweg was chosen to replace von Bülow as the next German Chancellor; however, Bethmann Hollweg fared no better than the three previous Chancellors before him. He was unable to achieve a stable parliamentary base, which meant that his government had to rely on the Kaiser, the military and the bureaucracy.[244] There were continued financial crises in connection with continued fleet buildup. Parliamentary deadlock ensued when two of the largest political parties refused to cooperate further enhancing the role of the Kaiser in the decision making process.[245] The imperial entourage began to take charge and manipulate the Kaiser into making decisions that would benefit them and their interest. Fresh tensions began to arise between the Reich bureaucracy and the Kaiser's court over foreign and domestic policies.[246] The entourage began to act more militaristic. The civilian Reich administration was viewed with growing hostility, while the government began to have more and more problems keeping the armed forces under control. Secretary of the Navy Tirpitz began to pursue his own policy counter to Chancellor Bethmann-Hollweg, even though he was subordinate to him. The army then began to deviate from the civilian government's line both at home and abroad.[247] Each of these problems was being watched by the other powers, England in particular due to the naval buildup issue.

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[243] Ibid., 96-97

[244] Fulbrook, 143

[245] Ibid.

[246] Berghan, 242.

[247] Ibid.

However, as alarming as all these events were, they were not the only things that pushed the other powers into war with Germany.

Colonialism was becoming more and more popular with Europeans in the 1880's. To the people of the newly formed German Empire, colonialism was symbolic of being a legitimate European power. Bismarck, when he was Chancellor, was not a proponent of colonialism. By his estimation, Germany did not have the fleet strength to protect colonies nor the wise or stable bureaucracy to manage them.[248] Moreover, he believed that Germany was too immature as a nation to manage the problems and issues that accompany colonial possessions.[249] Nonetheless, in 1883-1884 Bismarck changed policy concerning the establishment of German colonies. This was mainly due to the collapse of the capitalist world of industry and finance markets in 1882. Germany needed to secure markets at home and simultaneously preserve foreign trade.[250] The prospect emerged that German exporters might be excluded from markets in which they were already established and also from new markets in the interiors of the African and Asian continent.[251] Of course, this was not the only reason. Politics played a large part in all of Bismarck's decisions and colonialism was not an exception. Colonialism offered a way to attract the support of several interest groups in a critical election year: industrialist seeking to dump their products, merchants eager to expedite the exchange of goods, Hanseatic cities whose lifeblood was maritime commerce and patriots who

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[248] Otto Pflanze, *The Period of Fortification 1880-1898,* 114-115.

[249] William Osgood Aydelotte. *Bismarck and British Colonial Policy: the Problem of South West Africa, 1883-1885*. (New York: Octagon Books, 1974). 18.

[250] Pflanze, 121.

[251] Ibid.

swelled with pride at the thought of Germany becoming a world power.[252] However, Bismarck would never have allowed the acquisition of colonies if the foreign relations in Europe had not been stabilized as to not cause any harm to Germany. At that time, it was possible to conduct a diplomatic struggle for territories and spheres of influence overseas without jeopardizing Germany's position in Europe.[253] An example, Bismarck's colonial policy took advantage of unclaimed, ownerless lands that adjoined British colonies or lay near British strategic routes in hopes to start a quarrel with Great Britain that would draw France closer to Germany as allies.[254] Nonetheless, this plan ultimately failed to draw the envisioned support from France and by 1885 Bismarck was already taking the first steps to distance himself from Paris and to improve his relationship with London.[255] Competing smartly with Russia and France in the colonial world, Britain had opened diplomatic doors for a Germany desperate to establish its presence there. In the final analysis, without British neutrality Germany's forward leaps during the 1890's, both colonial and European, would have been impossible.[256] Once Germany had begun to colonize a colonial empire was established quickly. In 1884, colonies at the Cameroon's, German South-West Africa, and New Guinea were established; followed by German East Africa in 1885 and Samoa in 1899.[257] By 1914

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[252] Ibid., 122.

[253] Ibid.

[254] It must be noted that while a quarrel was the intended result, the lands in question were not of enough value to provoke war, a fact that Bismarck knew above all else. They were also of no concern to anyone else. A. J. P. Taylor. *Germany's First Bid for Colonies, 1884-1885; a Move in Bismarck's European Policy.* (London: Macmillan and Co., Ltd.,1938). 6.

[255] Kennedy, *Anglo*, 184.

[256] Ozmet, 235.

[257] Taylor, *Germany's*, 3.

the German overseas empire amounted to one million square miles and 15 million people, though Britain's empire was 13 times larger with 33 times the population. For the Kaiser and many German statesmen and intellectuals a *Weltpolitik* was vital to make Germany a great power.[258] But while Bismarck's colonial dispute was in direct relation to European alliances later disputes with European powers had no such relation.[259] After Bismarck left office the government intentionally sought for popularity and prestige by disputing with Britain over colonial possessions. While colonies were becoming increasingly popular with the German people, there was a growing concern over the government's policy towards Britain. This policy would help to counteract the new regimes reputation for being excessively accommodating to the British.[260] In fact, in 1894 Germany challenged or quarreled with Britain concerning Samoa, the Congo, the Sudan, Morocco, Turkey, and Portugal's African colonies. The dismissal of Caprivi and his replacement by Hohenlohe did not interrupt the pattern. Germany intervened in the settlement of Japan's war against China in 1895 even though there was no Far Eastern interest. The purpose of this activity was due to the groundless fear that Britain would make new gains in the region.[261] Germany was not always wrong in these disagreements, but the government's tactics and apparent lack of motive confused and annoyed the British without achieving anything of consequence for Germany. The

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[258] David Reynolds. *Britannia Overruled: British Policy and World Power in the 20th Century.* 2nd ed. (Singapore: Pearson Education Limited, 2000), 74.

[259] Ibid, 6.

[260] Donald Kagan. *On the Origins of War and the Preservation of Peace*. (New York: Doubleday, 1995). 130.

[261] Ibid.

Germans did not realize that their policy and manner were causing increasing ill will in Britain to the extent that any possibility of an alliance with Britain was not possible.[262] In 1904, Britain and France signed the Entente Cordiale a series of colonial agreements between the two countries. The most important aspect to come out of this agreement was that each agreed to give the other a free hand in Morocco and Egypt. These agreements actually eased tensions between the two countries. While it was not an alliance but dealt directly with the colonial questions it did presage a positive change in relations between England and France.[263] This did not bode well for Germany.

With France obtaining Britain's blessing for a free hand in Morocco, French Foreign Minister Théophile Delcassé proposed a series of reforms to the Moroccans that would turn Morocco into a French protectorate.[264] Because of the Madrid Convention of 1880, Germany was supposed to be consulted on anything to do with Morocco; however the French did not want the Germans objecting to their plans so Delcassé did not confer with the Germans over this issue. Annoyed that they were not consulted about this the Germans postured as if it never happened and that Morocco was yet an independent country. In 1905, von Bülow was able to convince the Kaiser Wilhelm II to stop at Morocco near the end of his cruise. While in Morocco the Kaiser asserted Germany's equal rights there, Germany's defense of free trade, and Germany's support of Moroccan independence. Wilhelm also made it very clear that Germany was willing to defend her own interest.[265] A conference was convened from January to April 1906 in

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[262] Ibid., 130-131.

[263] Ibid., 145.

[264] Ibid.

[265] Ibid., 146.

Algeciras, Spain to resolve the Moroccan issue. To Germany's dismay only two of the attending nations supported Germany's position. The conference gave control of the Moroccan police to Spain and France and gave France economic control of the country. This was a humiliating defeat for Germany who gained nothing from the conference, saw how unreliable Italy was as an ally who didn't support them, and instead of weakening the entente between France and England had strengthened it.[266]

Due to Germany's aggressiveness in the army and navy buildup and colonization, England began to look towards an alliance with Russia. Instead of intimidating Britain into complaisance, Germany's aims had produced a new alignment that the Germans normally would have thought totally inconceivable, an alliance between France, Britain and Russia known as the Triple Entente.[267] However, Sir Edward Grey, Britain's foreign minister, wanted to limit the use of the Triple Entente to deter German aggression. Not as a prelude to war. The Triple Entente would get its first test of strength in 1911, again in Morocco. Morocco had become quite anarchic since the first Moroccan Crisis and the French were forced to send in an army to Fez to break a siege of the city by insurgent tribesmen.[268] The French acted without consulting either Germany or Spain and their continued occupation went beyond what was permitted by the Treaty of Algeciras in 1906 and the Franco-German Accord of 1909[269]. The French colonist's

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[266] Ibid., 146-148.

[267] Ibid., 152-153.

[268] Ibid., 168.

[269] A temporary agreement between France and Germany where Germany recognizes certain French interest in Morocco in return for economic concessions.

plan was to use this incident as a pretext to make Morocco a French protectorate.[270] Germany wanted to use the incident as a way to get compensation and prestige back from the failure of the First Moroccan Crisis. In July 1911 Germany sent the gunboat Panther to anchor off the Moroccan port of Agadir. This threw the Triple Entente into confusion. Russia stayed neutral, Britain was split over whether to help France or not since France was clearly in the wrong and France felt as if she was being abandoned by the two other powers. However, it was Germany's aggressive nature that pushed Britain into supporting the French. Germany's veiled threats and innuendos of war with France pushed Britain to strengthen ties with France. Talk of war filled the streets and back alleys of Europe. In the end France and Germany agreed on the cession of a small and worthless piece of the Congo to Germany in return for the abandonment of Morocco.[271] However, the results of the Second Moroccan Crisis infuriated the German people and talk of war was becoming more and more prevalent.

Upon being asked what might start the next big war, Bismarck replied, "Some damned silly thing in the Balkans." Throughout Bismarck's tenure as minister-president, the problem of the Balkans had repeatedly been an area of great concern in Europe. Since Napoleon's defeat at Waterloo the question of what to do with the Balkans and the dying Ottoman Empire was being asked by every major European power. The Congress of Berlin tried to answer this question. This congress was convened in 1878 to keep Europe from erupting into war. Chaired by Bismarck, the congress was to help alleviate the concerns of the major powers after the defeat of the Turks by the Russians.

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[270] Ibid.

[271] Ibid., 168-173.

When the dust had settled and the conference was over, Austria-Hungary had gained Bosnia Herzegovina; Romania, Serbia and Montenegro got their independence and Russia acquired the territory of Bessarabia.[272] Britain was secure knowing that Turkey still had control of the straits and Dardenelles. This settlement known as the Treaty of Berlin achieved its main goal, to keep the peace in Europe, but it angered the Russians who had won the war but lost almost everything gained at the conference. In 1908 Austrian Foreign Minister Baron Alois Lexa von Aerenthal met with Russian Foreign Minister Alexander Izvolsky because of continued agitation from Serbia and Montenegro, who were disturbing the provinces of Bosnia-Herzegovina. The purpose of the meeting was to come to an agreement that would be beneficial for both sides. Aerenthal wanted to officially annex Bosnia-Herzegovina since suzerainty belonged to Turkey even though Austria had occupied the provinces since 1878. This action would end Serbia's hopes of gaining Bosnia-Herzegovina in the event of the collapse of Turkey.[273] To achieve this end Austria would need support, especially against Serbian claims to Bosnia. Russia could give them that support. However, Russia would expect something in return. Izvolsky requested free passage through the Bosporus straits for Russian ships and also the ships of countries bordering the straits and the Black Sea. With these concessions he felt he could persuade the Russian people to accept the annexation of Bosnia-Herzegovina.[274] Timing was the most important aspect of this

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[272] Langer., 161.

[273] It was Serbia's hopes to create a Greater Serbia of unified Slavic states by bringing in Bosnia-Herzgovina. Serbia did not want Bosnia-Herzegovina to be ruled by anyone else but Serbia and was willing to go to war to prevent it. Hew Strachan. *The First World War.* (New York: Penguin Group, Inc., 2004)., 4-9.

[274] Kagan., 160-161.

agreement. Izvolsky needed the announcement of the annexation to come after he had prepared the Russian government. However, soon after the agreement was reached between the two Foreign Ministers it began to unravel. Izvolsky learned that the Russian government would not abandon interest in the Slavic lands for access through the straits. To the Russian government this agreement amounted to no more than a complete betrayal of their Serbian allies, something that they could not do. The Russian government then proceeded to tell Izvolsky to reject the annexation and to demand an international conference to review it .[275] Things went from bad to worse when Bulgaria announced its independence from Turkey and the next day the Austrian Foreign Minister announced the annexation of Bosnia-Herzegovina. The Austrian Foreign Minister had agreed to inform the Russian Foreign Minister when he was about to announce the annexation. He did not, causing the timing of the announcement to be at the worst possible time for the Russian. With his policy in shambles and Russian public firmly against him, Izvolsky began to worry that Aerenthal might reveal details about his willingness to surrender Serbian and Montenegrin interest to achieve his purpose.[276] For the remainder of the crisis he would do what he could to salvage his prestige by denouncing Austria's actions and demanding an international conference.

Reaction to the news of annexation was mixed in Austria and Serbia. The Austrian people were euphoric about the addition to their empire and celebrations occurred throughout the country. On the other hand the Serbian population was outraged at the

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[275] Ibid.

[276] Ibid.

Austrian transgression. For the next six months, the threat of war hung over Europe.[277] All European countries held talks. Izvolsky began working to get a revision of the straits deal and compensation for Serbia and Montenegro.[278] However, he hit a roadblock when he discussed Serbian compensations with the British Prime Minister Grey. Grey was all for compensating Serbia, but not at the expense of Turkey like Izvolsky wished. Instead he wanted it to be at the expense of Austria. Serbia at first called for the signatory states of the Berlin Treaty to compel Austria to rescind the annexation. When this did not work, Serbia then began to demand compensation for this affront.[279] Talk of war began to circulate in Austria and Serbian circles. Serbia sent delegates to all European countries but Austria to push its demands for compensation. The Serbians were forced to accept the annexation when they discovered that Russia would not back any Serbian action.[280] This humiliating slap in the face to the Serbian people would in the end produce many underground organizations one of which was The Black Hand. This organization would ultimately have a hand in the assassination of Archduke Ferdinand and propelled Europe into war.

While the Bosnian crisis was not the final incident that would start World War I, it was one of the factors that lead up to the war. The biggest problem to come out of the crisis was the rousing nationalistic ambitions in Serbia and the other Balkan countries. The agitation of the Balkan countries came to a head in 1912 when Serbia, Bulgaria, Greece

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[277] Misha Glenny. *The Balkans: Nationalism, War and the Great Powers, 1804-1999*. (New York: Penguin Group, 1999.). 290.

[278] Kagan, 162.

[279] Glenny, 290.

[280] Ibid., 291.

and Montenegro formed the Balkan League with the sole intention of driving Turkey out of the Balkans. In October of 1912, Montenegro followed by the rest of the Balkan League declared war on Turkey.[281] The League's quick victories over the Turkish forces alarmed Austria who knew that when the war with Turkey was over Serbia would try to turn the League towards Bosnia-Herzegovina to take Bosnia-Herzegovina from Austria. Russia, in order to show support for Serbia began to mobilize forces in Galicia on the Austrian border. Austria, in turn, mobilized forces on the Galician border and in Bosnia-Herzegovina. It seemed as if Europe was going to war. However, in November the Bulgarians suffered defeat by the Turks in a major battle and peace talks began immediately.[282] The Russians, fearful that the Bulgarians would take Constantinople, abandoned Serbia and Serbian claims in order to help support Turkish claims to the city. During the conference Britain and Germany worked together to restrain their partners.

After the First Balkan War was officially over, Serbia decided to seize all of Macedonia and not give Bulgaria its promised share. In retaliation Bulgaria attacked both Serbia and Greece. With Bulgaria's focus on Serbia and Greece, Rumania decided to attack Bulgaria from the north. At the Peace of Bucharest in 1913, Bulgaria was stripped of almost all gains from the first war, Turkey gained Adrianople, Rumania gained Dobrudja and both Greece and Serbia acquired more territories.[283]

For Austria, the Bosnian Crisis and the two Balkan Wars had sufficiently weakened any once held power and prestige. The biggest threat now came from Serbia, which

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[281] Kagan, 178-179.

[282] Ibid., 179.

[283] Ibid., 180-181.

had grown in size and power. Serbia was eager for revenge after the many perceived humiliations that Austria-Hungary had heaped upon it. Time was ripe for war and the final spark would be the assassination of the heir apparent Archduke Ferdinand.

In the years leading up to the war, Germany attempted to prevent war. During the Bosnian Crisis and the two Balkan Wars, Germany distanced herself from Austria while not completely abandoning her. Along with Britain, Germany managed to restrain Austria and Russia after the first Balkan War. However, from the 1890's to 1912, Germany had significant disagreements with all the major powers except Austria-Hungary. Colonialism, Naval expansion and failed alliances all played a part in deteriorating Germany's position with all the other major powers. England didn't trust Germany, France wanted the French provinces of Alsace Lorraine back, and Russia wanted to protect Russian Balkan interest. The only German allies remaining were Austria-Hungary and Italy. In the end, it was Germany's promise to support Austria-Hungary that would drag the nation into the most devastating war in over a hundred years.

The main thing is to make history, not write it.

Prince Otto von Bismarck-Schonhausen

Conclusion

The Bismarck Plan: German Unification and the Balance of Power

Shortly after the Berlin Wall was razed in November 1989, the governments of the German Democratic Republic (GDR) and the Federal Republic of Germany (FRG), East and West Germany, began the process that had occurred only once before - the unification of Germany. But while the recent unification process would have the same result, the paths to unification of these two periods were distinctively different. For one, the Germany of 1989 had been separated politically by the victorious allies (France, Britain, Russia & the US) after World War II. The Germany of 1871 had been united by combining the Monarchy of Prussia with various other German principalities. Unlike the period of time, at the end of World War II, these principalities had never before been unified. Also, the method of unification of the two separate German states, in two separate periods, was quite different. At the conclusion of the Cold War, symbolized so strongly by the fall of the Berlin Wall, the German people and the governments of East and West Germany were free to become a unified Germany as they had been roughly 44 years before, at the launch of the War. For the resulting combined Germany of today, unification was the effort of many governments. The unification of Germany in 1871 was far more the plan of one man, Bismarck, emerging from within a German state, unifying diverse Germanic geographical and political entities.

Unification had not originated with Bismarck alone. It was a concept that had been passed down since the days of the Roman Empire. The French revolution and the European revolutions of the 1830's and 1840's have also played a major role in encouraging the idea of German unification by promoting nationalism. Bismarck

understood nationalism and he would use this concept to aid in the creation of his unified Germany under Prussian rule, for Bismarck was a Junker (Prussian landed gentry) therefore his loyalties were to the Prussian crown and more than to any nationalistic fervor. He was aware that in order for Prussia to survive and become a major force in European politics economic resources and popular support of the Germanic peoples were needed. Since in the 1800s, nearly all of the German principalities that were not under Austrian protection were used as buffer states to protect central Europe from France. Bismarck would have to be skillful enough to make these principalities unify into one nation under the Prussian monarchy without upsetting the balance of power of Europe. The methodology of Bismarck's plan was two-fold. -The first part of Bismarck's plan was to unite all the German principalities under the Prussian monarchy, thus forming Germany. He did this deftly while maintaining the balance of power in Europe. The second part was to forge alliances and relationships in all geographical and political directions, so that Germany would be closer to each of the potentially contending parties than they were to each other.[284] However, Bismarck did not adhere to a strict by-the-book plan, as traditional European diplomacy expected, but with variances, which provided for alternative courses of political action. Typically these courses were twofold in character: -alternative solutions to a particular political problem or alternative possibilities of an alliance with opposed political forces.[285]

Unfortunately Bismarck's Overall Plan had one major flaw. He never shared his plan or took into account a Germany without his leadership. Thus, the nuances and inner

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[284] Kissinger, 122.

[285] Sheehan, 164.

workings of his alliance system were lost when Bismarck was dismissed from office in 1890. The chancellors that replaced Bismarck never truly understood his system of alliances. Exacerbating their ignorance of plan, they were also not given the freedom or flexibility to act on their own as Bismarck certainly was with Wilhelm I. The result was that while, Bismarck possessed a strong personality and had the permission and freedom to influence people into his line of thinking most of the time, the chancellors who followed did not and could not.

Bismarck's goal was a Unified Germany built upon a Prussian monarchy, which was recognized by all as a legitimate European power, and he succeeded.

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